Zero-to-One Territories for a Consumer Bank

Where a new consumer-banking business could be built in the next five to ten years, mapped onto the eight life territories of the Bank of the Future framework

Executive summary of a source-verified research sweep · October 2026

The question	If three of us left to start a company in consumer banking and pitched a venture investor for $50 to 100 million, what would we build, for whom, why would it win, and what are the risks? Invent, not improve. Stay a bank. Be additive to work already in motion.
The frame	The eight life territories of the Bank of the Future framework (worldview, independence, partnerships, domicile, income, caregiving, transfer, rupture) are the master frame. Twelve seeded territories and eleven candidates surfaced in the sweep were tested as falsifiable opportunity hypotheses, each homed under a life territory. The sponsor's value-chain and distance-from-core frameworks were used as lenses.
The method	The September 2026 corpus supplied the demand evidence. Two web research slices per territory covered who is building at each moment, what failed, what a regulated deposit bank could own, and what the law allows. A separate compile pass per territory merged, pruned and re-verified every cited number against the fetched source. A separate adversary per territory then argued each survivor down. 374 verified findings (302 new, 72 carried from the corpus), 876 sources.
This document	Written for the sponsor and the product-strategy group that will run ideation against this map. It gives the framework recommendation, the ranked hit list, a verdict per territory, the stress-test log and the gaps. The full finding table is published beside it as a CSV.

How to read the verdicts. Each opportunity hypothesis was tested, not confirmed. **Survives** means the evidence supports it as written. **Narrows** means only a smaller claim survives, stated in the text. **Dies** means the evidence contradicts it. Each finding carries a confidence rating (High, Medium, Low) calibrated to how well its sources support that specific claim, and an evidence type. **Flagged** means the source has an interest in the result.

Finding IDs in brackets point to the register in Appendix A and the CSV.

Contents

Executive summary 6

The answer to the case 6

Why the seeds narrowed 6

The framework result 7

What the sponsor brief got wrong about the franchise 7

What to do with this 7

1. The framework memo 9

1.1 The master frame is the eight life territories 9

1.2 What the outcome record says about each frame 9

1.3 The catch for this sponsor 10

1.4 Recommendation 10

1.5 Corrections to the sponsor brief 11

2. The hit list, as the evidence allows 12

2.1 How to read the verdicts 12

2.2 The ranked list 12

2.3 Hypotheses that die 15

2.4 Screening scores for the survivors 16

2.5 What this means for the list the sponsor asked for 17

3. Territory verdicts 18

3.1 Shaping One's Financial Worldview 18

3.2 Becoming Financially Independent 19

3.3 Forming and Dissolving Partnerships 20

3.4 Establishing Domicile 21

3.5 Income Maturity 22

3.6 Caregiving Obligation 23

3.7 Transfer Between Generations 23

3.8 Rupture and Recovery 24

3.9 Cross-cutting mechanisms 25

4. The stress-test log 27

4.1 Survivors 27

4.2 Kills the adversaries re-examined and upheld . . . 31
4.3 Corrections the stress test made to the compile . . . 31
4.4 Reliability across the list . . . 31
5. Gaps and next research . . . 32
5.1 Internal measurements that decide a verdict . . . 32
5.2 External research and records requests . . . 33
5.3 Regulatory dates to watch . . . 34
5.4 What a second sweep should do differently . . . 34
6. Method and limits . . . 35
6.1 How the sweep ran . . . 35
6.2 What verification found . . . 36
6.3 Limits . . . 36
6.4 Files . . . 37
7. Addendum: follow-up pass on the kill tests . . . 38
7.1 Outcomes by kill test . . . 38
7.2 What changed in the list . . . 39
7.3 A note on the complaint data . . . 39
7.4 The second sweep . . . 40
8. The second sweep: positions and edges . . . 41
8.1 What the second sweep found . . . 41
8.2 Verdicts . . . 43
8.3 What this means . . . 44
8.4 Gaps . . . 44
9. The battlefield: acute pain by life stage . . . 45
9.1 Shaping One's Financial Worldview . . . 45
9.2 Becoming Financially Independent . . . 46
9.3 Forming and Dissolving Partnerships . . . 46
9.4 Establishing Domicile . . . 47
9.5 Income Maturity . . . 48
9.6 Caregiving Obligation . . . 49
9.7 Transfer Between Generations . . . 49
9.8 Rupture and Recovery . . . 50

9.9 Cross-cutting 51
9.10 Where the battlefield is densest 51

Executive summary

The answer to the case

The sponsor asked for a map of where a zero-to-one consumer-banking company could be built, so that ideation can run against a frame rather than at random. The sweep tested twelve seeded territories and eleven candidates it surfaced, each written as a falsifiable hypothesis and homed under one of the eight Bank of the Future life territories. It found demand evidence for nearly all of them, supply evidence that most are already served, and right-to-win evidence that a regulated deposit bank of Capital One's size holds an ownable edge in almost none.

Of 23 opportunity hypotheses, none survives as a zero-to-one territory for a bank. One survives as an adjacency worth a measured test (death and estate, as survivor navigation on the bank's own account-settlement process). Thirteen survive as features of products the bank already runs, each with a kill test the bank can run on its own data inside a quarter. The remaining nine die on the evidence. The sponsor's list of ten to fifteen territories does not exist on this record, and this document says so rather than filling the list with weaker entries.

Why the seeds narrowed

Three patterns repeat across every territory.

- **The pain is real, but it is income, price or policy, not a missing product.** Childcare cost, rent arrears, medical debt, student debt and home-insurance premiums are all measured in the corpus. In each case the cause sits outside anything a deposit account can change, and the money that does fill the gap arrives through an employer, a hospital, a preparer, a platform or a public programme [caregiving-15, rupture-20, independence-81, domicile-24].
- **Where a product gap exists, someone already fills it or already failed in it.** Rocket owns the whole home-purchase chain and still lost money [domicile-03]. CareCredit finances care at 290,000 points of care [rupture-01]. Remitly and Wise price remittances under 4% while banks charge 13.64% [worldview-03]. Five couples-money apps failed or stalled without a disclosed user count [partnerships-01, partnerships-14]. Estate planning is already bank-distributed through Trust & Will [transfer-02]. A top-ten regional bank shipped caregiver delegated access in 2025 on a vendor platform any bank can buy.
- **The bank's edge, where it exists, is the account it already holds, and that makes every survivor a feature.** Every narrowed form came to rest on the same asset: the deposit account where income lands and from which money leaves. That asset supports a retention feature, not a new company. The sponsor's own exclusions then apply: features drift into money assistants, agentic servicing, fraud protection or infrastructure, which Section 5 of the brief rules out.

The framework result

The sponsor's three frameworks were tested against the published literature and against the origins of the large consumer-finance outcomes of 2010 to 2026. Framework A (money moment) is the life-territory frame in its mature form. It says where to look and holds the demand evidence, but no large winner except SoFi documents a moment as its origin [framework-14]. Framework B (value-chain position) survives and generates as well as tests: Affirm and Klarna began at checkout on a bank balance sheet [framework-13]. Framework C (distance from core) is a risk label only. A fourth frame the sponsor did not list explains most of the outcome sample: cost structure, distribution and regulatory position [framework-01, framework-02, framework-03, framework-09, framework-10]. Most of those edges belong to challengers and cannot be copied by a bank this size, which is why the life-territory sweep found features rather than companies. Chapter 1 gives the recommended carve: life territories to say where to look, the fourth frame to screen for an ownable edge, Framework B to test position, Framework C to label risk.

What the sponsor brief got wrong about the franchise

The franchise compile corrected eight statements in the brief from filings and regulator records: the bank does offer small-business banking; it closed the Brex acquisition in April 2026; the Discover acquisition brought three payment networks and personal loans; it briefly held and then sold Discover's home loans in 2025, telling the OCC it could not compete with nonbank mortgage lenders; a found-money product (Capital One Shopping) already exists; and the venture arm, the "modern core" and the debit-skewed customer base could not be verified from outside [franchise-01 to franchise-07]. The 360 Savings record (a $425M settlement approved in April 2026, still under appeal) narrows the "trust from holding assets" claim, and the OCC's 2020 consent order on cloud risk controls contradicts "decades of risk capability" on technology risk [franchise-09, franchise-10].

What to do with this

1. **Run the kill tests before ideating.** Thirteen of the surviving forms have a kill criterion that is an internal data query or a one-quarter controlled test. Chapter 4 lists them. Most will end the feature; the few that survive are retention work for the owning teams, not territories.
2. **Measure the one number that decides the adjacency.** Death and estate turns on whether heirs keep a dead customer's money at the bank. Capital One's own estate-settlement records can answer it in weeks.
3. **Re-aim the hunt at position and edge, not moments.** The evidence says a bank this size can own two things on the fourth frame: distribution to its existing primary-account base, and funded positions in other firms' flows. The next sweep should start from positions in flows (where money changes hands and a balance sheet is needed) and from the assets the brief omitted (network ownership), and ask which of the eight life moments they touch, rather than the reverse.
4. **Treat an empty field as a negative result.** In partnerships, the absence of a scaled player after five attempts is evidence about the economics, not an opening. The same reading applies

to decumulation and to couples' money.

The full finding table (every number re-verified against its source) is published beside this document as a CSV, and every bracketed ID in this text points to a row in it. A follow-up pass after publication closed two kill tests and left the two top-ranked survivors unresolved on demand (Chapter 7). A second sweep, starting from positions in money flows and the edges a bank this size can hold, found one large regulatory edge with no consumer product on it and nine positions that die or narrow to features (Chapter 8). Chapter 9 sets the right-to-win screens aside and maps the battlefield: three to five areas of acute, measured pain per life stage, which are the durable part of this map and the ground ideation should start from.

1. The framework memo

The sponsor offered three ways to carve the zero-to-one space: by money moment (Framework A), by value-chain position (Framework B), and by distance from the core (Framework C). His working hypothesis was to generate with A, classify risk with C, and stress-test with B. The sweep tested each against two kinds of evidence: the published literature behind each frame, and the actual origins of the large consumer-finance outcomes and failures of 2010 to 2026, read from filings and regulator records.

1.1 The master frame is the eight life territories

The project owner's Bank of the Future framework already carves consumer financial life into eight territories, each with a verified insight corpus: shaping a financial worldview, becoming financially independent, forming and dissolving partnerships, establishing domicile, income maturity, caregiving obligation, transfer between generations, and rupture and recovery. This is Framework A in its mature form. It replaced the sponsor's list of money moments as the spine of the sweep, and the 271-row corpus supplied the demand evidence (pain, size, why now) for every territory without new research.

The life territories do one job well: they say where to look, and they hold the demand side. They do not pick winners, and the evidence says they cannot.

1.2 What the outcome record says about each frame

Framework A, money moment: a prompt for generating ideas, not a predictor of outcomes. Its method has no published validation in consumer finance. The jobs-to-be-done exemplar is a milkshake case with no finance example, and the only bank life-event evidence found is a consultancy survey with partial disclosure [framework-05]. In the outcome sample, one large US firm had an origin shaped like a moment: SoFi in student-loan refinance, and even SoFi needed gain-on-sale funding and a bought charter to scale [framework-14]. Robinhood's first-investor base is a loose fit reached through price [framework-11]. None of the sampled failures died for lack of a moment [framework-16]. Filings record products, not founders' reasoning, so this is an absence of evidence rather than proof.

Framework B, value-chain position: survives, and generates as well as tests. Affirm and Klarna, two of the largest consumer-credit outcomes, began from a position at merchant checkout, and both ran on a bank balance sheet [framework-13]. A Federal Reserve governor's September 2026 description of the agent-payment stack names networks, AI firms and platforms and does not mention banks, so B's disintermediation question is live [framework-04]. The record cuts the other way too: Google Plex and Diem were attempts to take new positions, and both failed [framework-16]. B's published literature is advocacy and vendor sizing with no disclosed method [framework-06], so its case rests on outcomes, not on its literature.

Framework C, distance from core: a risk label only. The main published critique of the three-horizons model says horizons are not bound by time and that incumbents fail at Horizon 3

for reasons of culture and process [framework-07]. C does describe what happened to Rocket Money, a found-money app that reached scale only as a line inside a parent [framework-15], and to Goldman's failed ring-2 consumer push [framework-16]. Both support C as a way to label risk. Neither shows it can pick winners.

A fourth frame the sponsor did not list: cost structure, distribution and regulatory position. It explains most of the outcome sample. The unit cost of US financial intermediation has sat near 2% for 130 years, and that high cost is what draws entrants [framework-01]. Chime's scale rests on interchange that is exempt from the Durbin cap because its partner banks are small [framework-09]. Revolut entered on cheaper foreign exchange [framework-12] and Robinhood on zero commission [framework-11]. Big tech enters finance from a customer base it already owns [framework-03]; Cash App acquired customers through free peer-to-peer payments and Nubank through unpaid referrals [framework-10]. About 60% of shadow-bank mortgage growth is attributed to regulatory differences [framework-02]. Market cycle is a timing condition, not a carving axis: Coinbase's revenue and Revolut's wealth line follow the crypto cycle [framework-11, framework-12].

1.3 The catch for this sponsor

Several of these edges belong to the challenger and cannot be copied by a bank of Capital One's size. The Durbin exemption is one. Regulatory arbitrage against banks is another. What a bank this size can own on the fourth frame is distribution (an existing primary-account base) and funded positions in other firms' flows.

The franchise evidence sharpens this. The deposit base is large ($475.8B at end-2025, sixth in the US after Discover) and rated high quality, but part of it was inert rather than loyal, and the 360 Savings record (a 0.3% rate against up to 4.35%, a $425M settlement approved in April 2026 and still unpaid under appeal) sits on the public record [franchise-02, franchise-09]. The "decades of risk capability" claim is contradicted on technology risk by the OCC's 2020 consent order, lifted in 2022 [franchise-10]. The modern core, the first-party data asset and the venture arm could not be verified from outside. The asset the sponsor omitted is network ownership: Discover, PULSE and Diners Club, with $401.8B of volume [franchise-05]. The "simple products" posture is a choice made more than once, most recently when the bank sold Discover's home loans within six months and told the OCC it could not compete with nonbank mortgage lenders [franchise-04].

1.4 Recommendation

Use the eight life territories as the map. Their job is to say where to look, and the corpus already holds the demand side for each. Do not use them to decide what to pursue. Run every candidate through three filters, in this order:

1. **Edge, the fourth frame, as the main screen.** Name the cost-structure, distribution or regulatory edge, and check whether a bank of Capital One's size can hold it. Durbin-exempt interchange fails this test. An existing primary-account base passes. Drop any candidate with no ownable edge, however acute the pain.

2. **Framework B, for position.** Does the opportunity sit in a flow the bank can occupy and fund, as Affirm and Klarna did at checkout, or in one where networks and AI platforms hold the customer? Generate candidates from B as well as test with it.
3. **Framework C, last, as a risk label.** Ring 1 is a new model inside an owned product, ring 2 a category others offer, ring 3 new to the world. Treat ring 2 as adjacency with a poor incumbent record.

A candidate needs all four filled in to rank: a life territory supplies the moment and the demand evidence, the fourth frame supplies the economics, B supplies the position, and C supplies the risk label. The hit list in Chapter 2 is built this way, and it is why most of the sponsor's seeds narrow to features or adjacencies rather than ranking as zero-to-one territories.

1.5 Corrections to the sponsor brief

The franchise compile corrected eight statements in the sponsor's Section 4 [franchise-01 to franchise-07]:

- Small-business banking is offered: business checking, business savings, banker-led lending and small-business cards.
- The Brex acquisition was signed 2026-01-22 and closed 2026-04-07 ($5.15B at signing, about $4.5B at close); it extends the enterprise into corporate cards and spend management.
- The adjacency list omits the Discover acquisition (closed 2025-05-18), which brought personal loans and three payment networks.
- "No international" is true only for consumer deposits; the enterprise runs card businesses in the UK and Canada.
- "No mortgage" was briefly untrue in 2025, when the bank held Discover's home loans and then sold them for $8.8B.
- "No student lending" holds, but a CFPB order on Discover's student-loan servicing runs to December 2030.
- A found-money product already exists: Capital One Shopping, free, with Capital One Travel gated to credit cards.
- The venture arm, the "modern full-stack core" and the "customer base skewed toward debit spenders" could not be verified from any public source.

2. The hit list, as the evidence allows

The sponsor asked for ten to fifteen territories, each a falsifiable hypothesis, screened and ranked. The sweep ranked all 23 hypotheses and the candidates the corpus raised. It applied the compilers' screening scores on the sponsor's eight criteria, then the adversaries' verdicts, reliability grades and kill criteria. The result is a short list of one adjacency and thirteen features, and a longer list of hypotheses that die.

2.1 How to read the verdicts

- **In, as adjacency.** A hypothesis that survives as a category others already offer (Framework C ring 2), with one ownable lever and a measurable kill test. It belongs on the list labelled as adjacency, not invention.
- **Feature, not territory.** A hypothesis whose surviving form is a change to a product the bank already runs. It has a kill test the owning team can run, and it should be handed to that team rather than ranked as a company.
- **Out.** The evidence contradicts the hypothesis as written and in every narrower form tried.

Reliability grades: **A** rests on filings, regulator records or administrative data with two independent sources; **B** on one primary source or company disclosure; **C** on trade press, vendor claims, researcher inference or corpus rows older than 2023.

2.2 The ranked list

Ranked by verdict, then by the strength of the pain evidence and the reliability of the surviving form. Feature clusters merge hypotheses whose surviving forms are the same build on the same product, as the adversaries recommended.

Rank	Hypothesis and surviving form	Home	Kill test (where to look)	Verdict	Grade
1	**T06 Death and Estate.** Survivor and executor navigation added to the bank's own account-settlement process, with the open question whether a payout by check becomes a retained heir relationship [transfer-08, transfer-02]. Includes the heir-obligation triage candidate as its content layer [transfer-22].	transfer	Share of estate-settlement checks deposited back to Capital One accounts at 3 and 12 months, from the bank's own Letter of Instruction records; Fifth Third's retention for Trust & Will users.	In, as adjacency	C

Rank	Hypothesis and surviving form	Home	Kill test (where to look)	Verdict	Grade
2	**Family authority over a parent's accounts, before and after death.** The caregiving delegated-access candidate (view-only and permissioned caregiver access) merged with rank 1, since it is the same adult child, the same account and the same handoff from power of attorney to executor [caregiving-08, caregiving-09, caregiving-13]. Huntington shipped it in 2025 on True Link's platform, so it is a buy-or-build feature.	caregiving, transfer	Huntington's enrollment and deposit attrition for enrolled owners (earnings calls, investor day); Capital One's yearly POA request volume and 24-month attrition of accounts with a POA or authorised signer.	Feature	C
3	**Deposit-underwritten small-dollar line.** T16 Expense-Shock Liquidity, T02 Income Smoothing's residue, T07's deposit-data input to Card, and the credit re-access candidate, all the same build: credit for the bank's own depositors on first-party deposit data, for accounts the $250 no-fee-overdraft rule turns down [rupture-09, rupture-06, income-21, independence-13].	rupture, income, independence	Held-out credit test on accounts below the $250 rule: 12-month charge-off and reborrow against the deposit margin those accounts carry; benchmark against the FDIC pilot (6.2%) and Chime's loss line [rupture-10, rupture-06].	Feature	C
4	**Joint-account exit and control terms.** T10's divorce half and the unmarried-partner candidate: moving a joint deposit account to single ownership in one flow, with two-key control in the interim, for married and unmarried partners [partnerships-02, partnerships-17, partnerships-21].	partnerships	Remaining-owner 12-month attrition after a joint account is converted, against matched single-owner accounts; yearly rate of restriction requests and co-owner disputes per 1,000 joint accounts; CFPB complaint narratives naming a joint account and an ex-partner. **Follow-up: 43 narratives in 3.5 years, kill confirmed (Chapter 7).**	Out (after follow-up)	C
5	**Tax-time routing.** T17 Tax Refund (the account the refund lands in, for filers moved off paper checks in 2026) merged with T05 First-Wealth On-Ramp (a paycheck-linked savings-to-IRA bridge on the 2027 Saver's Match, with a partner broker-dealer), since both sit at the tax return [income-16, income-13, independence-05, independence-07].	income, independence	12-month primary-account rate of 2026 accounts whose first credit was an IRS refund, against payroll-acquired accounts; IRS Statistics of Income on Form 8880 claims by IRA contributors under the cap; Treasury's TrumpIRA.gov listing criteria (January 2027).	Feature	B
6	**Deposit sweep option.** T03 Household Treasury's residue and the "own the sweep" candidate: a bank-run default sweep for balances above $25,000 into a third-party money-market fund under the broker exception, as a retention option, not a cross-institution agent [crosscut-16, crosscut-03, crosscut-07].	crosscut	Outbound ACH and wire data 2022-2024 by balance band, by receiving-institution type; the fund's servicing fee (prospectus fee tables) against the bank's net spread on 360 balances above $25,000. If the fee is below the spread, it dies before a pilot. **Follow-up: fee 15-25 bps against a 62-230 bps spread, kill confirmed (Chapter 7).**	Out as revenue case (after follow-up)	C

Rank	Hypothesis and surviving form	Home	Kill test (where to look)	Verdict	Grade
7	**Found-money debit extension.** T04 Found Money's residue: extending the subscription find-block-cancel tool Capital One has shipped for credit cards since October 2024 to 360 Checking [crosscut-08, crosscut-11, crosscut-21].	crosscut	12- and 24-month attrition and balance change for card customers who used block or cancel, against matched non-users.	Feature	B
8	**Agent permissions, limits and disputes in the bank app.** T08 Agent-Native Money's residue, conditional on a consumer agent-payment market that does not yet exist (Visa disclosed "hundreds" of agent transactions in December 2025) [crosscut-12, crosscut-14, crosscut-15]. Same control problem as rank 2 with a software delegate.	crosscut	Mastercard Chargeback Guide and Visa Core Rules 2026: if agent-error disputes get a network reason code with liability on the operator or merchant, the issuer app has nothing distinct. Visa Q4 FY2026 agent-transaction disclosure.	Feature	C
9	**In-app international send from checking.** T11 Cross-Border Lives' residue: a parity gap behind Chase (90+ countries in app) and SoFi; the remittance-tax exemption follows the customer's account, not the sender's provider [worldview-11, worldview-05, worldview-06].	worldview	Share of checking customers with recurring outflows to remittance providers (MCC 4829, known ACH originators) and whether they hold lower balances or churn more than matched peers.	Feature	C
10	**Credit-health coaching beyond the free tier.** T18's residue: paid coaching on top of CreditWise, with no negotiation or settlement, using the CROA exclusion for depository institutions [rupture-15, rupture-12, rupture-11].	rupture	A randomised paid tier inside CreditWise at $10 a month for revolvers; conversion and 6-month retention against Rocket Money's revealed level.	Feature	C
11	**Rent-history communication.** T15's residue: telling renting checking customers that Fannie Mae's DU already reads rent from any bank account, recipient-blind [domicile-12]. No build.	domicile	None needed; the GSE rule already applies to every bank's customers.	Feature (communication)	B
12	**Fixed-age separation triggers.** The age-21, 25 and 26 candidate as a trigger inside life-transition servicing; the age-25 fee cliff does not exist at Capital One [independence-23, franchise-01].	independence	Transaction-panel comparison six months either side of the 26th birthday for customers who lose parental health cover.	Feature	C
13	**Charity-care routing.** T12 Health Cost Finance's last residue: routing eligible patients to hospital financial assistance in states without presumptive-screening law. No revenue line; six states now require hospitals to screen [rupture-02, rupture-19].	rupture	Form 990 Schedule H Part III bad debt attributable to assistance-eligible patients, before and after presumptive-screening laws; Oregon Health Authority reports.	Feature (at most)	C
14	**Resilience lending.** T22's residue: a home-improvement loan with a disaster purpose, with no escrow or servicing seat [domicile-18, domicile-24].	domicile	Alabama FORTIFIED programme waitlists and the share of owners who self-fund beyond the $10,000 grant.	Feature (weak)	C

2.3 Hypotheses that die

Hypothesis	Why it dies	Grade of the kill
T01 Home Purchase End to End	Rocket owns the full chain and lost $234M in 2025; banks make 3.6% of FHA and VA loans, where lower-equity buyers borrow; 70% of originations are securitised, so deposit funding does not set the price; Congress blocked bank real-estate brokerage in 2003; Capital One exited twice and told the OCC in 2025 it could not compete with nonbanks [domicile-03, domicile-06, domicile-07, franchise-04].	A
T09 Embedded Earning-Platform Banking	The platform owns the earner and can end the programme by non-renewal (Payfare lost DoorDash and sold for $95M net of cash); the silent-provider role is where the 2024 enforcement landed; sponsor economics rest on the under-$10B Durbin exemption Capital One lacks; the brief already assigns BaaS to an executive [income-07, income-09, income-10, income-12].	B
T12 Health Cost Finance (as financing)	Synchrony finances care at 290,000 points of care on deposit funding and has drawn CFPB action twice for deferred interest; provider vendors own interest-free plans; the medical-debt reporting rule was vacated in July 2025; the pain is coverage and price [rupture-01, rupture-05, rupture-04, rupture-20].	B
T15 Rent as a Rewards and Credit Rail	Debit interchange on a $1,500 rent payment is about $0.96 at Capital One's size; the one scaled rent-rewards card reportedly cost Wells Fargo up to $10M a month; landlord portals own the rail; rent history already reaches the GSEs from any account [domicile-13, domicile-08, domicile-11, domicile-12].	B
T19 Retirement Decumulation	Every income wrapper needs an insurer, a broker or a trust department; bank collective funds cannot be advertised; installments take under 0.5% of exiting plan assets; the vacated DOL rule helps whoever holds the rollover [transfer-12, transfer-13, transfer-05, transfer-14].	B
T20 Student Debt Choreography	The July 2026 caps are being filled by prime refinancing lenders (SoFi, Earnest at a 773 average FICO); the employer match belongs to plan sponsors; servicing is moving to Treasury; no switching evidence [independence-14, independence-15].	B
T21 Childcare Cost Finance	The burden is price and missing supply; 40% of working mothers of under-fives pay nothing; the 2026 tax changes flow through employer FSAs and a non-refundable credit; no financing product with disclosed users exists [caregiving-15, caregiving-18, caregiving-14, caregiving-05].	B
T22 Home Insurance and Disaster Exposure (as written)	A national bank may not underwrite insurance; Capital One has no escrow or servicing seat; Florida's crisis reversed on state reform; insurtechs have no stable underwriting profit [domicile-18, domicile-17, domicile-16].	B
T23 Family Formation Finance	Couples are merging money less (23% of married couples hold no joint account); five couples-money apps failed or stalled; fertility is employer-paid at scale through Progyny and clinic-financed by specialists; Venmo Groups and Apple Card Family own coordination without pooling [partnerships-17, partnerships-01, partnerships-04, partnerships-14].	B
T10 Life-Transition Banking (as a priced bundle)	Both homed halves failed: caregiving bundles are employer-paid human help, divorce decisions belong to the court and the mortgage servicer, and no willingness-to-pay evidence exists in any transition [caregiving-04, partnerships-10, partnerships-09].	B

Hypothesis	Why it dies	Grade of the kill
Candidates that die	Retirement-balance-backed liquidity (a pledge is a plan loan under IRC 72(p)); parent-to-young-adult flows (incidence shown, no gap); co-resident shared accounts (Braid called itself unviable; Venmo chose a ledger); renter cash-gate (Flex serves 3.2M renters and applied for a charter); renter-owned screening record (consumer-reporting-agency exposure); kids as the first relationship (crowded, and Capital One already runs MONEY Teen); social media as the bank-choice channel (a bought channel); tax-calendar liquidity (unsized niche); consumer stablecoin savings (already on the sponsor's ring 3); auto cost (fails the additive screen).	C

2.4 Screening scores for the survivors

The compilers scored each surviving hypothesis on the sponsor's eight criteria, with a Finding ID behind each score. The adversaries then cut most "Strong" white-space scores to "Weak" where a scaled player was found after compile. The table shows the post-stress view.

Hypothesis	Pain	Size	Why now	Right to win	White space	Disinter-mediation	Feasibility	Additive
T06 Death and Estate	Moderate	Weak	Weak	Moderate	Weak	Moderate	Moderate	Strong
Family authority over a parent's accounts	Moderate	Unknown	Weak	Moderate	Weak	Moderate	Moderate	Moderate
Deposit-underwritten small-dollar line	Strong	Moderate	Weak	Moderate	Weak	Moderate	Strong	Weak
Joint-account exit and control terms	Strong	Weak	Weak	Weak	Moderate	Weak	Moderate	Strong
Tax-time routing	Moderate	Moderate	Moderate	Weak	Weak	Moderate	Weak	Moderate
Deposit sweep option	Moderate	Unknown	Moderate	Moderate	Weak	Moderate	Moderate	Strong
Found-money debit extension	Moderate	Moderate	Weak	Weak	Weak	Weak	Strong	Weak
Agent permissions in the app	Unknown	Weak	Weak	Moderate	Weak	Moderate	Moderate	Strong
In-app international send	Moderate	Moderate	Weak	Weak	Weak	Moderate	Moderate	Strong
Credit-health coaching	Moderate	Unknown	Strong	Moderate	Weak	Weak	Moderate	Unknown

Two readings follow. First, "Additive" scores Strong in most rows because Capital One has nothing in motion there, and that is the weakest reason to pursue anything. Second, "White space" scores Weak in every row after stress: the sweep found an incumbent or a failed pure-play at every moment it looked.

2.5 What this means for the list the sponsor asked for

The ten-to-fifteen list does not exist on this evidence, and a list padded with the features above would mislead the room. Three things do exist:

- **One adjacency with a cheap, decisive test** (rank 1), which the bank should measure before anyone ideates on death and estate.
- **Thirteen features with kill tests**, most of them internal data queries. Running them is the fastest way to turn this map into decisions, and it costs no product work.
- **A framework result that changes where to look.** Zero-to-one outcomes for a bank this size came from position in a flow and from an edge in cost, distribution or regulation, not from a life moment. The next hunt should start from positions and edges (funded positions in other firms' flows, the existing primary-account base, the network seat the brief omitted) and ask which life moments they touch.

3. Territory verdicts

One section per life territory, in the order of the framework's wheel. Each gives the demand picture the corpus already held, then each opportunity homed there: the hypothesis as the sponsor or the sweep wrote it, what the evidence left standing, and the verdict. The cross-cutting bucket follows. Finding IDs point to the published table.

3.1 Shaping One's Financial Worldview

The moment. Before a consumer has a financial life, school, family and social media shape what they believe money is for. The corpus shows that early independent minor accounts leave no banked advantage by 24 and are followed by worse credit at 21 to 24 [worldview-20]; that saving habits track current cash flow and paycheck timing, not childhood formation [worldview-21]; and that remittance senders exit with tenure, with a net loss of 533,208 Mexican remitters in 2025 and the obligation falling from 15% in the second generation to 4% in the third [worldview-16, worldview-18].

T11 Cross-Border Lives. *Hypothesis:* immigrant and multinational households moving money, credit history and identity across borders are an unserved territory. *What stands:* nothing of the territory. Money movement is served at scale and low price: Remitly sent $74.9B in 2025, Wise's take rate is 0.52%, digital providers price at 3.87% while banks are the costliest channel at 13.64% [worldview-01, worldview-02, worldview-03]. Credit-history portability is a B2B utility Nova Credit sells to Chase and HSBC [worldview-08]. ITIN account opening is standard, though Capital One's 360 Checking accepts an ITIN only from citizens and permanent residents, which is narrower than Bank of America [worldview-06]. The 1% remittance tax in force since January 2026 exempts any transfer funded from a bank account or a US card, regardless of who sends it, so it is an edge over cash agents and over no one else [worldview-11]. Chase offers in-app sends to 90+ countries, which removes the "large banks offer only branch wires" premise. *Verdict:* Feature, not territory. The residue is a missing in-app international send on checking, a parity gap for the money-movement team. Grade C.

Candidates. Kids and family money as the first relationship dies: the category is crowded (Greenlight reports 6.5M family members) and Capital One already runs MONEY Teen Checking from age 6 [worldview-09]. Social media as the bank-choice channel dies: it is a channel anyone can buy on the same FTC terms, with no measure of its role in bank choice [worldview-15, worldview-23].

Territory takeaway. Worldview formation has no transaction of its own. School financial education was bank-sponsored, partly for CRA credit, and Blackbaud wrote EVERFI off with a $405.4M charge [worldview-10]. The territory contributes nothing to the list.

3.2 Becoming Financially Independent

The moment. The corpus shows the median under-35 household has $0 in retirement accounts while 98.6% of families hold a transaction account [independence-16]; that credit invisibility is now 2.7% of adults and mostly a pre-25 timing problem [independence-19]; that the measured lift from cash-flow data is about 4% more approvals among applicants who already have files [independence-20]; and that "too little money" is the top reason non-investors give, at 44.9% against 5.0% citing a bad past experience [independence-17].

T05 First-Wealth On-Ramp. *Hypothesis:* the step from saver to investor is unserved for the mass market, and a bank could own it with a model that is not a brokerage. *What stands:* neither half. The on-ramp is served: Robinhood has 27.0M funded customers with an IRA match, and SoFi and Cash App build investing into their apps [independence-01]. There is no wide legal route for a bank without a brokerage: collective funds are fiduciary-only and cannot be advertised, and Regulation R allows only sweep, custody, trust or nominal referral [independence-05]. Treasury chose BNY and Robinhood as the initial trustee for the new child accounts [independence-06], and the 2027 Saver's Match is claimed on the tax return and is being built to flow into employer plans [independence-07]. The downmarket models never reached venture scale: Stash sold at $425M against a $1.4B peak, the Acorns SPAC was terminated, Goldman sold Marcus Invest for an immaterial price [independence-03, independence-04]. *Verdict:* Feature, not territory. A savings-to-IRA routing feature on checking with a partner broker-dealer, merged with the tax-time routing of T17. Grade C.

T07 Economic-Mobility Underwriting. *Hypothesis:* cash-flow and behavioural underwriting could open credit to customers the bureau model excludes, at scale. *What stands:* a model input for a business that exists. Capital One Card already chose to originate subprime, with 27% of domestic card balances at FICO 660 or below [independence-13]. Cash-flow scores are now a vendor commodity (UltraFICO through Plaid since May 2026, Prism Data) [independence-08]. Upstart shows lender score cut-offs, not missing data, gate most denials [independence-09]. Chime already serves 9.5M members with secured cards and deposit-based pre-approval [independence-10]. The only edge is first-party deposit data while Section 1033 is enjoined, and that is temporary [independence-12]. *Verdict:* Feature, not territory. It fails the additive screen as a Bank play and belongs to Card's credit-model team. Grade C.

T20 Student Debt Choreography. *Hypothesis:* borrowers facing the 2026 caps would switch to a bank that manages, refinances and employer-matches student debt. *What stands:* nothing. Grad PLUS ended and Parent PLUS was capped from July 2026, and the gap is being filled by prime refinancing lenders: SoFi's originations rose 170% in Q2 2026 and Earnest doubled volume at a 773 average FICO [independence-14]. The employer match belongs to plan sponsors, and servicing of defaulted loans is moving to Treasury [independence-15]. *Verdict:* Out. Grade B.

Candidates. Parent-to-young-adult support flows: incidence shown (59% of parents helped in the past year), no gap shown, and it serves advantaged families most [independence-22]. Out. Fixed-age separation cliffs: only the age-26 insurance cliff carries a measured cost, and the age-25 fee cliff does not exist at a bank with no fees [independence-23, franchise-01]. Feature at most.

Territory takeaway. The bank's only asset here is the paycheck landing in the account, and the 2027 Saver's Match is being built to flow around that account. Defensive retention work for the deposits and Card teams, not a place to hunt for a company.

3.3 Forming and Dissolving Partnerships

The moment. Cohabitors number 18.4M and hold joint accounts at only 16%; married couples with no joint account rose from 15% to 23% between 1996 and 2023 [partnerships-16, partnerships-17]. Unmarried breakups are now the main way young couples split, with no decree to divide anything [partnerships-21]. Unwinding a mortgage and joint credit takes months to years, and the release decision belongs to the servicer and the investor's rules, not the bank [partnerships-20, partnerships-10]. Divorce is getting rarer and older: 2.4 per 1,000 in 2023, with growth among women 55 to 64 [partnerships-19].

T10 Life-Transition Banking (divorce half). *Hypothesis:* bundled financial choreography for a transition can be priced as a service. *What stands:* one servicing change. Capital One's 360 Checking agreement lets any joint owner withdraw or close without consent [partnerships-02], it offers no joint card [partnerships-13], and the money decisions that matter (the decree, the mortgage release) sit with parties the bank cannot bind [partnerships-09, partnerships-10]. The leading online divorce service charges $400 to $2,000 for the whole process on a seed-stage balance sheet [partnerships-08]. *Verdict:* Feature, not territory. Joint-account exit and control terms for the deposit servicing team. Grade C.

T23 Family Formation Finance. *Hypothesis:* couples forming households would use a bank that merges money, finances fertility and unwinds cleanly. *What stands:* nothing distinct. Merging is what couples are moving away from. Fertility is employer-paid at scale (Progyny: $1.29B revenue, 7.2M covered lives), set by state mandates, and consumer-financed by specialists on a deferred-interest model regulators have criticised [partnerships-04, partnerships-05, partnerships-06, partnerships-07]. Coordination is owned by platforms that do not hold money: Venmo Groups, Splitwise, Apple Card Family (moving to Chase). Five couples-money pure-plays failed or stalled without a disclosed user count, and Braid's founder said it was not a viable business [partnerships-01, partnerships-14]. A Durbin-capped bank earns less per shared dollar than the fintechs that could not make it pay [domicile-13]. *Verdict:* Out. Grade B.

Candidates. Infrastructure for unmarried partners from joint start to unwind: 84% of cohabitors hold no joint account, and the only new element is an exit clause any bank can write, whose enforceability under state survivorship law was not checked [partnerships-22, partnerships-02]. Merged into the T10 feature. Shared accounts for co-residents who are not couples: Venmo chose a ledger for roommates, and the one funded attempt called itself unviable [partnerships-23, partnerships-14]. Out.

Territory takeaway. An empty field here is a negative result, not an opening. The one thing the sponsor should take is that the bank's own joint-account contract is the problem the moment exposes, and fixing it is servicing work.

3.4 Establishing Domicile

The moment. 49.7% of renter households are cost-burdened, 23% fell behind on rent (33% under $25,000 income), and rent reporting reaches 8% of renters by self-report [domicile-19, domicile-20, domicile-21]. First-time buyers are held back by the down payment (68% cite it; nearly 90% lack the FHA minimum for an average home), not by process; 26% of buyers paid cash [domicile-22, domicile-23]. Premiums rose 8.7% faster than inflation, and the highest-risk ZIP codes pay 82% more [domicile-24].

T01 Home Purchase End to End. *Hypothesis:* an AI-mediated bank could compress search, negotiation, financing and closing and capture the fees realtors, brokers and title companies take. *What stands:* nothing. The fee pool is real (commissions and related costs about $170B) and commissions stayed sticky after the 2024 settlement, with 88% of buyers still using an agent [domicile-01, domicile-02]. But Rocket already owns the full chain and lost $234M in 2025 [domicile-03]; Better and Doma lost heavily through the rate cycle [domicile-04, domicile-05]; Congress blocked bank real-estate brokerage in 2003 and RESPA caps referral fees [domicile-06]; banks make 3.6% of FHA and VA loans and 70% of originations are securitised, so deposit funding does not set the price; and Capital One exited in 2017, sold Discover's home loans in 2025, and told the OCC it could not compete with nonbank lenders [franchise-04, domicile-07]. *Verdict:* Out. Grade A for the kill.

T15 Rent as a Rewards and Credit Rail. *Hypothesis:* renters would route rent through a bank that turns the largest monthly payment into rewards and credit history. *What stands:* a communication. Debit interchange on a $1,500 rent payment is about $0.96 at Capital One's size [domicile-13]; the one scaled rent-rewards card reportedly cost Wells Fargo up to $10M a month before it exited, and Bilt rebuilt so that rent points depend on non-rent spend [domicile-08, domicile-09]; landlord portals already monetise the rail (AppFolio's payments-led services are $721.5M of $950.8M revenue) [domicile-11]. The credit leg already exists for every bank's customers: Fannie Mae's DU reads rent from any account through a lender-ordered report and ignores who received the payment [domicile-12]. *Verdict:* Out as a rail; a communication at most. Grade B.

T22 Home Insurance and Disaster Exposure. *Hypothesis:* homeowners facing insurance withdrawal would use a bank that finances resilience, bridges claims and holds the escrow. *What stands:* a weak niche. A national bank may not underwrite insurance; Capital One has no escrow or servicing seat; Florida's Citizens fell from 1.41M to 254K policies on state reform while California's FAIR Plan grew 157%; Hippo and Lemonade have no stable underwriting profit; disaster rails are federal or insurer-funded [domicile-18, domicile-17, domicile-16]. *Verdict:* Out as written; resilience lending is a home-improvement loan with a disaster purpose. Grade C for the residue.

Candidates. The renter cash-gate folds into the small-dollar line: Flex already serves rent timing for 3.2M renters and applied for a Utah bank charter in July 2026 [domicile-10]. The renter-owned screening record carries consumer-reporting-agency exposure (TransUnion $15M, RentGrow $2.25M orders) [domicile-14]. Both Out.

Territory takeaway. In housing, the seat that matters is the mortgage lender or servicer, and Capital One gave that seat up on purpose. Any domicile idea that needs it should be dropped before ideation.

3.5 Income Maturity

The moment. 30% of adults say income varies month to month and 11% struggled to pay bills because of it; strict gig work is 3 to 9% of adults [income-01, income-19, income-20]. Earned wage access costs about $69 a year per user, 96.6% of it expedite fees [income-02]. Refunds are the largest cash event of the year for 29% or 40% of families (two JPMorgan Chase Institute pages conflict), and $324.8B was refunded through May 2026 [income-23, income-80]. Free File reaches about 3% of returns, and the IRS suspended Direct File after 59% of registrants never filed [income-24, income-16].

T02 Income Smoothing. *Hypothesis:* gig and variable-income workers would pay for or switch banks for guaranteed cash-flow smoothing underwritten on earnings data. *What stands:* the same small-dollar line as T16. Every scaled product sells speed on earned pay, not smoothing; Even dropped smoothing within two years and the UK's SteadyPay runs it for about 9,000 users [income-02, income-03]; the CFPB's December 2025 opinion excludes any provider that underwrites individual workers, so the underwritten version carries the full credit regime [income-05]; Capital One already gives away early paycheck and no-fee overdraft [income-06]. *Verdict:* Feature, merged into the small-dollar line. Grade B.

T09 Embedded Earning-Platform Banking. *Hypothesis:* banking inside gig, creator or employer platforms, with the bank as brand or silent provider, is a zero-to-one territory. *What stands:* the known BaaS position. The platform owns the earner: Payfare lost DoorDash, fell more than 75% and sold to Fiserv for $95M net of cash [income-07]; DoorDash and Uber brand their own accounts with a small sponsor bank in the footnotes and disclose no uptake [income-08]; Synapse's $60M to $90M shortfall and the 2024 orders on Evolve, Blue Ridge, Sutton, Piermont and Lineage show where the silent-provider role lands [income-09, income-10]; the sponsor model rests on the Durbin exemption Capital One lacks [income-12]. *Verdict:* Out. Grade B.

T17 Tax Refund and Embedded Tax. *Hypothesis:* a bank that files, advances and plans around the refund captures the refund flow and the year-round relationship. *What stands:* a seasonal acquisition campaign. Filing, advance and account are already bundled by H&R Block with Pathward ($1.7B of advances through 42,000 offices), by Intuit, by Cash App and by Green Dot (12.0M refunds processed in 2025, marketed to the never-banked) [income-13, income-14]; bank refund-anticipation loans were ended by supervisors in 2010 to 2012 [income-15]; the 2026 paper-check phase-out moved about 10M filers in one season, and 98% of refunds now go by direct deposit [income-16]; the largest refund-to-savings trial moved about 0.7% of filers. *Verdict:* Feature, merged into tax-time routing. Grade B.

Candidate. Tax-calendar liquidity for equity- and bonus-paid earners: the withholding rules are real, but 75% of adults at $100,000 or more already hold a three-month cushion and nothing sizes the population [income-18, income-26]. Out.

Territory takeaway. The money arrives through someone else's flow: employer payroll, platform, preparer. The bank's only role is the account it lands in, which is distribution for existing products.

3.6 Caregiving Obligation

The moment. 7.6M parents of minors also give eldercare [caregiving-19]; childcare costs 23 to 27% of income below poverty, with care deserts and a public funding cliff [caregiving-15, caregiving-16, caregiving-17]; 40% of working mothers of under-fives pay nothing [caregiving-18]; dependent-care FSAs reach 43% of private workers but 22% in service occupations [caregiving-06].

T10 Life-Transition Banking (caregiving half). *What stands:* nothing priced. Where a bundle is sold, the employer pays for human help (Cariloop supports 2M+ employees) [caregiving-04]; low-income caregiver pay is a Medicaid programme with required fiscal intermediaries, in every state [caregiving-07]; the cost of caregiving is time, foregone earnings and care services, none of them a bank flow [caregiving-20]. *Verdict:* Out. Grade B.

T21 Childcare Cost Finance. *What stands:* nothing. The pain is price and supply; the 2026 tax changes (FSA limit to $7,500, credit rate to 50%) flow through employers and a non-refundable credit; no financing product with disclosed users was found [caregiving-14, caregiving-05]. *Verdict:* Out. Grade B.

Candidate: adult children running a parent's money. The CFPB has asked banks to offer view-only access and convenience accounts since 2016; Chase and Bank of America offer only a no-access trusted contact; Capital One's pages show POA intake but no view-only layer [caregiving-08, caregiving-03, caregiving-09]. The adversary found that Huntington launched Caregiver Banking in August 2025 on True Link's platform, which sells to any bank, and FinCEN's 2024 data put about 80% of elder-exploitation filings on strangers, so the "watch the delegate" edge is the minority channel. *Verdict:* Feature, not territory, merged with T06 as family authority over a parent's accounts before and after death. Grade C.

Territory takeaway. The bank's asset at this moment is verifying who has authority over a parent's account, from power of attorney through death. That belongs with transfer, not in a caregiving territory of its own.

3.7 Transfer Between Generations

The moment. The Cerulli wealth-transfer figure moved from $84T to $124T between vintages and belongs to wealth managers; receipt is concentrated in top-income households and arrives after age 40 (the five-year receipt rate peaks at 11.2% for ages 56 to 65) [transfer-15, transfer-16]. Surviving spouses face collectors for debts they do not owe, heirs are pushed to refinance, and the reverse-mortgage heir clock runs 30 days [transfer-19, transfer-20, transfer-22]. About 12.5% of estates are litigated and fees run 2.9% in undisputed matters, in one county [transfer-18]. At separation, 58% of plan assets stay with the recordkeeper and 36% roll to an IRA; installments take under 0.5% [transfer-05].

T06 Death and Estate. *Hypothesis:* the wealth transfer has no good consumer product for the executor or heir. *What stands:* survivor navigation on the bank's own settlement process. Planning is served at consumer scale through banks (Fifth Third has delivered 39,000+ free wills through Trust & Will) [transfer-02]; bereavement navigation is served through insurers and employers (Empathy reaches 1 in 5 claimants) and direct to families (Atticus) [transfer-01, transfer-03]; small-estate affidavits let executors collect without probate up to $50,000 to $208,850 by state [transfer-10]; UPL law caps advice at forms and routing [transfer-11]. The bank is where a death becomes legally visible (FDIC six-month rule, Treasury reclamation) [transfer-08], but Capital One's estate package settles every account by check to the estate or beneficiaries, which can be deposited anywhere, and no source measures whether heirs stay. *Verdict:* In, as adjacency. The only survivor on the list, and it turns on one unmeasured number. Grade C.

T19 Retirement Decumulation. *Hypothesis:* a bank could own decumulation without being an insurer or a broker. *What stands:* nothing. Annuities need an insurer and licensed staff [transfer-13]; bank collective funds cannot be advertised and Reg R limits referral pay [transfer-12]; the vacated DOL rule helps whoever holds the rollover [transfer-14]; Retirable shows any fintech can rent a sponsor bank for the residue [transfer-07]. *Verdict:* Out. Grade B.

Candidate: heir and survivor obligation triage. Four pains documented by the CFPB and HUD share a pattern, but each is owned by a counterparty the bank cannot bind, and Capital One already publishes the generic version on its "Can you inherit debt?" page [transfer-22, transfer-11]. Feature, folded into T06 as content.

Territory takeaway. Transfer turns on whether heirs keep a dead customer's money at the bank. Capital One can measure that from its own settlement records before anyone ideates here.

3.8 Rupture and Recovery

The moment. 63% would cover a $400 expense with cash and 12% could not pay by any means; 37% of the lowest-income and 97% of the highest-income households can cover $1,600 [rupture-16, rupture-17]. 23M adults owe medical debt, 3M owe more than $10,000, and 57% of adults under $40,000 hold health-care debt [rupture-19, rupture-20]. More than 5M defaulted student-loan borrowers face offsets, and credit limits stay at 10 to 15% of prior levels after a filer's score recovers [rupture-21, rupture-23]. For high-headroom households a shock is a liquidity event, not a hardship [rupture-17].

T12 Health Cost Finance. *Hypothesis:* a bank could negotiate, finance and plan medical bills. *What stands:* a routing service with no revenue line. Synchrony finances care at 290,000 points of care on 84% deposit funding and drew CFPB action in 2013 and 2023 for deferred interest [rupture-01, rupture-05]; PayZen and Cedar sell interest-free plans to providers; HealthEquity holds 10.6M HSAs through employers [rupture-02, rupture-03]; the medical-debt reporting rule was vacated in July 2025 [rupture-04]; six states now require hospitals to screen for charity care, and in Oregon 80% of patients who got help never applied. *Verdict:* Out as financing; charity-care routing at most. Grade C.

T16 Expense-Shock Liquidity. *Hypothesis:* households that cannot cover a shock would switch to a bank that pre-approves shock liquidity from deposit data, priced below overdraft and cash-advance apps. *What stands:* a change to one parameter of an existing product. Capital One already charges no overdraft fees, so "priced below overdraft" has nothing to undercut; its rule declines accounts under $250 a month in deposits [rupture-09]. Chime and Varo pre-approve deposit-based advances, and Chime's transaction and risk losses rose 85% to $407M in 2025 [rupture-06]. Bank of America, U.S. Bank and Wells Fargo sell flat-fee small loans; 80% of Bank of America's 1.6M loans went to repeat borrowers, and the FDIC's pilot found fees rarely cover the loan [rupture-07, rupture-10]. *Verdict:* Feature, not territory. Grade C.

T18 Debt and Credit-Health Subscription. *Hypothesis:* revolving-debt households would pay a subscription to a bank that manages, consolidates and negotiates their debt. *What stands:* paid coaching beyond a free tier Capital One already runs. CreditWise is free and open to non-customers; Credit Karma earns $2.64B giving the tools away; Tally raised $172M and shut in August 2024; Ava is a $15.5M seed; the settlement half runs into the FTC's advance-fee ban and a $106.8M default judgment entered in October 2026 [rupture-12, rupture-11, rupture-13, rupture-14]. The one edge is that CROA excludes depository institutions, confirmed in the statute text [rupture-15]. *Verdict:* Feature, not territory. Grade C.

Candidates. Retirement-balance-backed shock liquidity dies on statute: a pledge of a plan interest is treated as a plan loan under IRC 72(p), and SECURE 2.0 already allows a $1,000 emergency withdrawal [rupture-22]. Credit re-access after distress is Capital One's secured-card business, with 2.4M+ customers reported to have raised their scores on it [rupture-23]. Feature, folded into the small-dollar line.

Territory takeaway. A shock is a cash-flow problem the bank should handle inside the accounts it already holds. It should not be ranked as a business to build.

3.9 Cross-cutting mechanisms

T03 Household Treasury. *Hypothesis:* trillions sit idle, and an agent that moves money across institutions to maximise return is a business-sized opportunity. *What stands:* a deposit-pricing decision. The NBER panel behind "idle" money shows no rate response above $25,000, but its authors read large balances as liquidity stores, and the panel cannot see money that left for money-market funds; $1.2T moved into those funds in 2023 [crosscut-16, crosscut-17]. The sweep business belongs to intermediaries: Wealthfront earns 74% of revenue from a sweep on $45.4B, paid by the banks that hold the cash [crosscut-01]. Schwab's 10-K shows that cash moving to yield costs the holder, which recovers only by owning the destination product, and Capital One sold its brokerage in 2018 [crosscut-03]. Its own deposit-pricing record is the exposure [crosscut-07]. *Verdict:* Out; the "own the sweep" candidate survives as a deposit option for the treasury and deposits owners, with an arithmetic kill test (fund servicing fee against net spread). Grade C.

T04 Found Money. *Hypothesis:* a bank that finds money customers are owed earns loyalty and a share of recovered value. *What stands:* a debit extension of a tool the bank already ships. Capital One has offered in-app subscription find, block and cancel for credit cards since October 2024, and Capital One Shopping covers the shopping half [crosscut-11]; people do pay for this, but to a

non-bank app (Rocket Money: $390M from 4.58M subscribers) [crosscut-08]; unclaimed property is free to claim and finders are regulated; the largest overpayment pool, $12B a year in overdraft and NSF fees, is banks' own revenue [crosscut-21]; the click-to-cancel rule was vacated and fee caps reversed [crosscut-10, crosscut-22]. *Verdict:* Feature, not territory. Grade B.

T08 Agent-Native Money. *Hypothesis:* when agents transact, the bank that authenticates, limits and settles for agents becomes the default. *What stands:* permissions, limits and disputes in the bank app, conditional on a market that does not exist. Visa reported "hundreds" of agent transactions in December 2025, Mastercard's "enabled" means eligible, OpenAI moved checkout out of ChatGPT in March 2026, and the only volume figure is sub-dollar machine traffic [crosscut-12, crosscut-13]. The networks own the credential and dispute layer; Capital One discloses agentic commerce only as a risk and has no agent-payments product, though it now owns a network seat through Discover [crosscut-15, crosscut-14]. *Verdict:* Feature, not territory. Grade C.

Bucket takeaway. Every mechanism narrowed into a feature of something Capital One already has, and each drifts into a Section 5 exclusion. The idle-cash premise is weaker than the corpus framed it.

4. The stress-test log

One adversary per territory argued each surviving form down from the verified rows, graded the reliability of the evidence behind it, and set a kill criterion that names a measurement. This chapter records, for each surviving form, the strongest objection, what the evidence does not say, the grade, and the kill test. The full arguments, with the counter-sources each adversary fetched, are in the per-territory stress files.

4.1 Survivors

T06 Death and Estate (In, as adjacency; grade C).

- *Strongest objection*. The bank's own process works against the claim: Capital One settles every account by a check to the estate or beneficiaries, which can be deposited anywhere, and no source measures whether heirs stay. The navigation category already has paid and free incumbents reaching families through insurers (Empathy) and direct (Atticus). Most estates are cheap and uncontested, and small-estate affidavits need no bank help [transfer-01, transfer-10, transfer-18].
- *What the evidence does not say*. No row measures heir retention, time to death notification or freeze duration; the distribution edge is a reading of 31 CFR 210 and 12 CFR 330, not an observation. The litigation and fee figures come from one California county before 2019. The Cerulli pool is a vendor projection that moved 47% between vintages.
- *Kill test*. Heirs keep less than a few percent of a payout at the bank twelve months later, from Capital One's own Letter of Instruction records matched to open accounts, or from Fifth Third's disclosed retention for Trust & Will users. A second kill: Empathy or Atticus distributed through a top-20 US deposit bank, which makes it a vendor-procurement decision.

Family authority over a parent's accounts (Feature; grade C).

- *Strongest objection*. Huntington, a top-ten commercial bank, launched Caregiver Banking in August 2025 on True Link's platform, which sells to any bank or credit union; the category is ring 2 and a buy-or-build decision. FinCEN's April 2024 analysis puts about 80% of elder-exploitation filings on strangers' scams, so the "watch the delegate" edge is the minority channel, and stranger fraud is out of scope under Section 5. Demand rests on a seller-sponsored poll and a 2013 figure with no method [caregiving-12, caregiving-22].
- *What the evidence does not say*. "No large bank offers it" was inferred from three bank pages. Huntington's permission details and $5 fee come from search summaries of pages that returned 403. No source compares exploitation under formal delegated access with the shared-login workarounds it would replace.
- *Kill test*. Huntington's enrollment reaching under 1% of consumer checking households within two years, or no attrition difference for enrolled owners; inside Capital One, yearly POA request volume and 24-month attrition of accounts with a POA or authorised signer against matched accounts.

Deposit-underwritten small-dollar line (Feature; grade C).

- *Strongest objection*. The declined segment is defined by low deposits (under $250 a month), so it holds little balance to retain, while Consumer Banking earned about 0.3% after tax on deposits in 2025 [franchise-03]. Chime's losses rose 85% to $407M on the same products; bank small-dollar balances ran 8.4% delinquent; 80% of Bank of America's loans went to repeat borrowers, which the FDIC exam manual names as a harm signal [rupture-06, rupture-07, rupture-10]. Capital One has already spent the price edge: no overdraft fees, free early paycheck [rupture-09, income-06]. Underwriting takes the product out of the EWA safe harbour into Reg Z credit [income-05].
- *What the evidence does not say*. No bank publishes small-dollar loss rates. No row says how many Capital One accounts fail the $250 test or what they hold. The retention rationale rests on a 2010 FDIC survey. The 4% cash-flow lift is an industry-funded simulation, and Capital One is a FinRegLab funder [independence-20].
- *Kill test*. A held-out credit test on accounts below the $250 rule: 12-month charge-off and reborrow rates against the attrition gap times the deposit margin those accounts carry. External benchmarks: the FDIC pilot's 6.2% and Chime's product-level losses if disclosed.

Joint-account exit and control terms (Feature; grade C).

- *Strongest objection*. The money pain sits with the mortgage and the decree, where the bank is absent; no row measures the deposit side of a separation (time to convert, frequency of one partner draining the account, remaining-owner attrition). The leading divorce service sells the whole process for under $2,000 on a seed-stage balance sheet, so the bank's slice has no visible price. Divorce is shrinking and ageing, and the growing young breakups are unmarried couples who hold few joint accounts [partnerships-08, partnerships-19, partnerships-17].
- *What the evidence does not say*. "Retention feature" is the compiler's inference with no attrition data. "No US bank programme" rests on three Capital One pages and one 403. Whether a pre-set exit clause is enforceable under state survivorship law was not checked.
- *Kill test*. Remaining-owner 12-month attrition after conversion against matched single-owner accounts (a gap under 5 points kills it); conversions under about 1 in 200 joint accounts a year; CFPB complaint narratives naming a joint account and an ex-partner in the low hundreds a year.

Tax-time routing: T17 and T05 (Feature; grade B).

- *Strongest objection*. The why-now was spent in one season: about 10M refunds went by paper check the year before the phase-out, and 98% went by direct deposit in 2026. Green Dot processed 12.0M refunds in 2025 for the never-banked and its active accounts still fell 6.8%, the only public sign of refund-to-account conversion, and it points the wrong way. The largest refund-to-savings trial moved about 0.7% of 680,000 filers. The Saver's Match is claimed on the tax return and is being built to flow into employer plans; Treasury chose Robinhood as the child-account trustee; a deposit-only IRA may not be listed on TrumpIRA.gov [income-16, income-13, independence-06, independence-07].
- *What the evidence does not say*. No source cuts refunds by income or destination account type. The 2.6x round-ups figure is a researcher's ratio of two CFPB numbers on an association the CFPB itself calls non-causal, from one app's opt-in users in 2019 to 2020.

- *Kill test*. 12-month primary-account rate of 2026 accounts whose first credit was an IRS refund, against payroll-acquired accounts; IRS Statistics of Income on Form 8880 claims by IRA contributors under the cap; Treasury's listing criteria in January 2027.

Deposit sweep option: T03 and "own the sweep" (Feature; grade C).

- *Strongest objection*. The NBER panel's authors read large balances as liquidity stores, not inattention, and the panel cannot see money that left for money-market funds; so either the rate-sensitive dollars already left without an agent, or the remaining money is liquidity a yield sweep does not serve [crosscut-16, crosscut-17]. The bank owns no fund, so a sweep moves the deposit into someone else's product and earns at most a servicing fee; Schwab recovered only by owning the destination [crosscut-03]. The disclosure a sweep needs (stating the yield gap) is the 360 Savings exposure [crosscut-07].
- *What the evidence does not say*. The statute reading (15 U.S.C. 78c(a)(4)(B)(v)) is the researcher's; the adviser and fiduciary questions were not researched. No row sizes bank-side sweep revenue. The 60 basis point fee is Wealthfront's, an intermediary's fee, not what a fund pays a bank.
- *Kill test*. The fund's shareholder-servicing fee (prospectus and SAI fee tables, bounded by FINRA Rule 2341) against the bank's net spread on 360 balances above $25,000; outbound ACH and wire data 2022 to 2024 by balance band and receiving-institution type.

Found-money debit extension: T04 (Feature; grade B).

- *Strongest objection*. Capital One already ships the narrow form for card customers, free, through Minna Technologies, and the sponsor's Section 5 rules out money assistants, which is what fee surfacing in the app is. People pay for this to a non-bank app as a subscription; no row shows found money raising retention [crosscut-08, crosscut-11].
- *What the evidence does not say*. No row gives dollars recovered by any found-money product. Usage of Capital One's own tool is undisclosed.
- *Kill test*. 12- and 24-month attrition and balance change for card customers who used block or cancel, against matched non-users. An internal query on a tool live for two years.

Agent permissions in the app: T08 (Feature; grade C).

- *Strongest objection*. No consumer agent-payment market exists; the networks are shipping the dispute layer (Mastercard's Agent Pay rests on its tokenisation and dispute management, with Verifiable Intent letting any party contest a transaction through chargeback rules); the bank's Reg E position is a liability before it is an asset, and regulators press banks to absorb scam-induced "authorised" losses [crosscut-12, crosscut-14, crosscut-15]. The residue sits between agentic servicing and fraud protection, both ruled out.
- *What the evidence does not say*. Applying 12 CFR 1005.2(m) to an AI agent is the researcher's reading; no regulator has said it. The network rulebooks were not opened.
- *Kill test*. The 2026 Mastercard Chargeback Guide and Visa Core Rules: if agent-error disputes get a network reason code with liability on the operator or merchant, the issuer app has nothing distinct. Visa's Q4 FY2026 materials for any consumer agent-transaction count.

In-app international send: T11 (Feature; grade C).

- *Strongest objection*. 26 USC 4475(c) taxes only cash and physical instruments, and (d)(1) exempts funds withdrawn from any bank account without naming whose, so a Remitly or Wise transfer pulled from a Capital One account is exempt on the same terms. Chase sells in-app sends to 90+ countries. Banks are the costliest channel (13.64% against 5.40%), and Remitly's own bank-account layer closed in 2023 for lack of scale [worldview-11, worldview-03, worldview-07].
- *What the evidence does not say*. The 13.64% figure is a 2024 global average including small and foreign banks. The cash share of US remittance funding, the one number that would size any tax effect, is unsourced.
- *Kill test*. Share of checking customers with recurring outflows to remittance providers and whether they hold lower balances or churn more than matched peers. If senders keep their deposits while sending through apps, there is no disintermediation.

Credit-health coaching: T18 (Feature; grade C).

- *Strongest objection*. CreditWise is free, open to non-customers, and includes a score, a simulator and alerts; Credit Karma gives the same away for $2.64B of lead revenue; Tally shut after $172M; a card issuer coaching debt reduction has a conflict with the balances it earns on [rupture-12, rupture-11, rupture-81].
- *What the evidence does not say*. The CROA exclusion is confirmed in statute text, but whether the Telemarketing Sales Rule reaches a bank-run product was not resolved. No row sizes paid demand.
- *Kill test*. A randomised paid tier inside CreditWise at $10 a month for revolvers; conversion and 6-month retention below Rocket Money's revealed level ends it.

Rent-history communication: T15 (Feature; grade B). Fannie Mae's DU reads rent from any bank's account through a lender-ordered report and ignores the recipient, so the credit leg already works for every bank's customers and the bank adds nothing by holding the account [domicile-12]. No kill test needed; nothing to build.

Charity-care routing: T12 (Feature at most; grade C). Six states require presumptive screening and Minnesota bars hospitals from enrolling a patient in a payment plan before screening; the step the narrow form gives a bank is becoming a provider duty, and it earns no fee. Kill test: Form 990 Schedule H Part III bad debt attributable to assistance-eligible patients, before and after screening laws.

Resilience lending: T22 (Feature, weak; grade C). Lending to households that cannot afford a premium adds a payment; rails are public or insurer-funded; federal climate-risk principles for large banks were rescinded in October 2025 [domicile-18]. Kill test: Alabama FORTIFIED programme waitlists and self-funded remainders.

Fixed-age triggers (Feature; grade C). The cost at 26 is an insurance bill, the age-25 fee cliff does not exist at a no-fee bank, and a birth date is not an edge [independence-23]. Kill test: a transaction-panel comparison around the 26th birthday.

4.2 Kills the adversaries re-examined and upheld

Follow-up note (Chapter 7): the T01 price-edge claim below ("no price edge exists") was tested on HMDA 2024 and 2025 data after publication and retired; depositories price lower, though the cause looks like borrower mix. T01's kill stands on the bank's exits and the nonbank share.

Each adversary was asked to reopen any compiler kill it thought wrong. None was reopened. The kills of T01, T09, T19, T20, T21, T23 and the T10 bundle stand on grade A or B evidence (filings, regulator records, administrative data), and the adversaries added evidence in each case: the 3.6% bank share of FHA and VA lending and the 70% securitisation rate for T01; the Harris poll's silence on priced bundles for T10; IRC 72(p) for retirement-backed liquidity; Venmo Groups and Apple Card Family for the coordination legs of T23.

4.3 Corrections the stress test made to the compile

- The "no large bank offers delegated caregiver access" claim is wrong: Huntington has since August 2025.
- The T04 additive screen missed Capital One's own subscription manager, live since October 2024.
- The 2.6x round-ups figure is a researcher's ratio on a non-causal association from one app's 2019 to 2020 users.
- The NBER deposit-inattention paper's authors read large balances as liquidity, not inattention, and the panel cannot see money that left for money-market funds.
- The remittance-tax exemption follows the customer's account, not the sender's provider, and Chase already offers in-app international sends.
- Capital One's estate package settles accounts by check to the estate or beneficiaries, which cuts against the "death-notification process as an asset" reading.

4.4 Reliability across the list

Every surviving form graded C except three (tax-time routing, found-money extension, rent-history communication) at B. No surviving form reached A. The pattern is consistent: the pain rows are administrative and regulator data; the supply rows are filings; the claims that make any of these a territory (white space, a retention motive, an ownable edge, willingness to switch) rest on company disclosure, trade press, researcher inference and absence of evidence. That is why the recommended next step is measurement, not ideation.

5. Gaps and next research

The sweep could not resolve three kinds of question. Each is listed with the step that would resolve it. Most of the first group are internal data queries Capital One can run in weeks; the second group needs primary research or a records request; the third is a watch list of regulatory dates that would change a verdict.

5.1 Internal measurements that decide a verdict

These are the kill tests from Chapter 4 that run on the bank's own data. Each one ends or confirms a feature, and together they would turn this map into decisions without product work.

- **Heir retention after a death (decides the only adjacency).** Match estate-settlement check payees and Letter of Instruction beneficiaries against open Capital One accounts at 3 and 12 months. Add the time from date of death to estate case open, to test whether the bank learns of a death before the insurer does.
- **Authority over a parent's account.** Yearly volume of power-of-attorney and authorised-signer requests by customer age; 24-month deposit attrition of accounts with a POA or authorised signer against matched accounts; a short survey of customers aged 40 to 60 on whether they help a parent bank and through which workaround.
- **The declined-overdraft segment.** Counts, balances and 12-month attrition of accounts failing the $250-in-two-of-three-months rule, against matched accounts; then a held-out credit test on a $250 to $500 line.
- **Joint-account separations.** Conversions from joint to single ownership per 1,000 joint accounts a year; restriction requests and co-owner disputes; remaining-owner 12-month attrition against matched single-owner accounts; share of 360 joint accounts that are funded and active 12 months after opening.
- **Refund-opened accounts.** 12-month primary-account rate of 360 Checking accounts opened January to April 2026 whose first credit is an IRS refund ACH, against payroll-acquired accounts.
- **Large-balance outflows.** Outbound ACH and wire data 2022 to 2024 by balance band at $25,000, by receiving-institution type (broker-dealers, fund transfer agents), paired with tenure after outflow.
- **Subscription manager effect.** 12- and 24-month attrition and balance change for card customers who used block or cancel since October 2024, against matched non-users.
- **Remittance senders in the base.** Share of checking customers with recurring outflows to remittance providers (MCC 4829, known ACH originators) and their balances and attrition against matched peers.
- **Card's use of deposit data.** A model-inventory check on whether Card's underwriting already takes deposit inputs, then a back-test on depositors declined by Card in 2024 to 2025 with and without 12 months of their own deposit data.

- **Teen-to-adult conversion.** Conversion of MONEY Teen Checking holders to 360 Checking at 18 and their adult retention, which decides whether the kids' candidate has any retention value.

5.2 External research and records requests

- **Willingness to pay or switch.** No opportunity in the sweep has any. A probability-panel item (commissioned, or proposed for a Federal Reserve SHED wave) asked of partnered adults who keep separate accounts, of adult children helping a parent bank, and of variable-income workers offered a priced liquidity line would close the demand gap for three feature clusters at once.
- **Depository versus nonbank cost on first-time purchase loans.** FFIEC HMDA public LAR data for 2024 and 2025 with the rate-spread and total-loan-cost fields, by lender type, loan type, LTV and score band. The only test that could reopen T01, and the bank's own 2017 and 2025 exits predict the result.
- **Huntington Caregiver Banking uptake.** Earnings-call and investor-day transcripts, or a vendor-diligence call with True Link on partner-bank adoption and retention.
- **Fifth Third's Trust & Will retention.** Investor relations, for the only disclosed bank case of estate planning as deposit retention.
- **Survivor-obligation frequency.** A local narrative search of the CFPB bulk complaints file for "deceased", "estate", "successor" and "surviving spouse", normalised by NCHS deaths (3.07M in 2024).
- **Where 2026's former paper-check refunds went.** A Bureau of the Fiscal Service records request, or a written question to the National Taxpayer Advocate for the 2026 Annual Report, on refunds by payment method and receiving-institution type.
- **GSE rent-history outcomes.** Fannie Mae and Freddie Mac loan-level data, or an FHFA request, on approvals flipped by rent history by year; the 17% is modelled and the 21,000 is undated.
- **Sweep fee against spread.** Money-market fund prospectus and Statement of Additional Information fee tables for bank-sweep share classes, set against the bank's internal funds-transfer price on 360 balances above $25,000.
- **Network rulebooks on agent disputes.** The 2026 Mastercard Chargeback Guide and Visa Core Rules, which decide whether an issuer app has anything distinct to offer on agent errors.
- **Charity-care residue after presumptive screening.** Form 990 Schedule H Part III and Oregon Health Authority financial-assistance reports, before and after 2024.
- **State law on joint-account exit terms.** The Uniform Multiple-Person Accounts Act adoptions and the statutes of the bank's largest deposit states, plus the Reg E Official Interpretations on loss allocation between joint owners.
- **Capital One facts that could not be verified from outside.** The debit-versus-credit customer split and income mix of the deposit base; deposit beta and switching; the venture portfolio; any independent assessment of the core platform; the deceased-customer, hardship and delegated-access processes beyond public help pages.

5.3 Regulatory dates to watch

- **January 2027: Saver's Match launch and TrumpIRA.gov listing criteria.** If deposit IRAs are listed and the claim can be routed from the bank's account, tax-time routing regains a thin foothold; if index-fund options are required, the bank is a referrer only.
- **Mid-November 2026: Treasury's customer-due-diligence proposal under EO 14406 section 3(b).** If it requires immigration-status collection for ITIN accounts, the cross-border residue becomes uneconomic for any bank.
- **Section 1033.** Enjoined and under reconsideration as of October 2026, with an August 2026 proposal at OIRA. A replacement rule that restores portability removes the one temporary edge behind deposit-data underwriting; one that sets access fees in incumbents' favour removes the cross-institution version of household treasury for good.
- **Fourth Circuit appeal 26-1807 (360 Savings settlement).** Briefs due November and December 2026. The outcome bears on every deposit-pricing feature, including the sweep option.
- **Flex's Utah industrial bank charter application.** Approval would leave no bank-specific edge in rent timing.
- **FTC rental-fee rulemaking (opened March 2026) and any re-proposed click-to-cancel rule.** Either would move the found-money and renter residues.
- **The bank-fintech guidance rescission proposed in September 2026.** Final adoption would ease, but not remove, the silent-provider exposure that killed T09.

5.4 What a second sweep should do differently

- **Start from positions and edges, not moments.** The framework evidence says zero-to-one outcomes for a bank this size came from a position in a flow and an edge in cost, distribution or regulation. A second pass should enumerate the flows where money changes hands and a balance sheet is needed (checkout, payouts, settlements, claims), the assets the brief omitted (network ownership, personal loans, the small-business book), and the primary-account base, and ask which life moments each touches.
- **Treat empty fields as negative results.** Where several pure-plays failed without a disclosed user count, the default reading should be that the economics do not work, and the research question becomes why.
- **Put demand measurement first.** The corpus holds pain; nothing holds willingness to switch. A single commissioned panel wave would do more for the next sweep than another round of supply research.
- **Keep the verification pass.** Every compile corrected numbers that the research pass had attached to real URLs, including one in the September corpus. The published table carries only what a compiler found on the page.

6. Method and limits

6.1 How the sweep ran

The sweep followed the project's hypothesis-led method: state a plausible answer early, then attack it until it survives or breaks. It ran in five stages over one working day, 26 October 2026, with about sixty agents.

1. **Scout.** The sponsor brief's twelve seeded territories, three frameworks and nine questions per territory were taken as hypotheses. The master frame was changed on the sponsor's instruction from the seeded money-moment list to the eight Bank of the Future life territories. Every seeded territory and every candidate found later was homed under a life territory as a falsifiable opportunity hypothesis (T01 to T12 seeded, T15 to T23 surfaced).
2. **Mine.** One read-only agent per life territory extracted the verified demand evidence (pain, size, why now) from the September 2026 corpus, mapped each corpus row to the opportunities homed there, and proposed candidates the seed list missed. No new research was spent on demand.
3. **Research.** Two web slices per life territory, each with a search budget of thirty and unlimited fetches: a supply slice (who is building at this moment, from filings and primary records, and what failed) and a right-to-win slice (what a regulated deposit bank could own, what the law allows, the additive screen, and the cost-structure, distribution or regulatory edge). Disconfirmation was mandatory in every brief. Two further slices covered the franchise facts and the framework evidence, and two scanned venture activity and consumer-pain data for missed territories.
4. **Compile and verify.** One agent per territory merged, pruned and cut the slice findings, then re-fetched every surviving URL and checked that each cited number, date and named fact appeared in the fetched text or in a locally saved full-text copy. The rule in every compiler brief: a live link is not a verified stat. Compilers wrote the verdicts, the screening scores, the corrections and the gaps.
5. **Stress-test.** One adversary per territory argued each survivor down from the verified rows, graded the reliability of the evidence behind the surviving form, set a kill criterion that names a measurement, and recommended whether it belongs on the hit list.

A merge script validated every compiled row against the taxonomy, the opportunity list and the controlled vocabularies before writing a byte of the final table, and an independent validator re-checked the result.

6.2 What verification found

Every compile pass corrected numbers that the research pass had attached to real URLs. Examples: a revenue growth figure stated as ten times that the source gave as three times; a plan-feature share attributed to a year the report did not cover; a table in the September corpus read one column off, which had put the highest average inheritance in the wrong age band; a "multi-billion-dollar loss" that the filing said was more than offset by a reserve release; three enforcement orders attributed to the wrong regulator; a shutdown dated a year early. The pattern matched earlier sweeps: links resolve, numbers drift. Every correction is listed in the per-territory compiler notes, and every row in the published table carries only figures the compiler found on the page.

The adversaries then graded reliability. Most surviving forms rest on grade B (one primary source or company disclosure) or grade C (trade press, vendor claims, researcher inference or corpus rows older than 2023) evidence. That grade is reported next to each verdict and should travel with it.

6.3 Limits

- **Demand is the weakest leg.** No willingness-to-pay or switching evidence exists for any opportunity in the sweep. The corpus measures pain, and the research measured supply and law. Whether a customer would switch banks for any surviving form is unmeasured, which is why most kill criteria point at a bank pilot or a disclosed uptake figure.
- **Capital One's own position is partly opaque from outside.** The debit-versus-credit customer split, deposit beta and switching, the venture portfolio, the core platform, and the deceased-customer, hardship and delegated-access processes could not be verified from public sources. Several additive-screen verdicts read "no evidence of a product", not "confirmed absent".
- **Regulatory status moved during 2025 and 2026 and was checked as of October 2026.** Section 1033 is enjoined and under reconsideration; the overdraft, medical-debt and click-to-cancel rules were repealed or vacated; the EWA proposal was withdrawn; the 2025 budget act's remittance tax, child accounts and loan caps are in force with proposed rules only. Any of these could move again.
- **Blocked hosts.** EDGAR full-text search, the Federal Register's HTML pages, ed.gov, several state statute sites, PitchBook, Crunchbase, most trade-press hosts and some investor-relations sites blocked automated fetches. Where a fact rests on a secondary record because the primary was blocked, the row says so and is rated Low.
- **Search budget.** Each research slice had thirty searches. Coverage of the long tail of startups is incomplete, and absence of a named player is not proof of absence.
- **Origins are read from filings.** The framework evidence tallies where large outcomes came from using products recorded in filings, not founders' reasoning. That favours cost and distribution explanations over moment explanations.

6.4 Files

- `findings.csv`: the published table, 255 rows, 16 columns, one row per verified finding, with Finding IDs that match the brackets in this document.
- Per-territory compiler notes and stress-test files, in the project folder, hold the verdicts, screening scores, corrections, gaps and the adversaries' arguments in full.
- The brief, taxonomy, opportunity list and scripts are in the project folder so that an additive pass can run the same way.

7. Addendum: follow-up pass on the kill tests

After publication, a follow-up pass ran the parts of Chapter 5 that could be done from public records: bank disclosures on caregiver and estate programmes, the CFPB complaint narratives, the HMDA lender-cost comparison, the sweep fee arithmetic, and the network rulebooks on agent disputes. It added 24 verified rows (IDs 90 to 99 within each territory) and changed two verdicts. The internal Capital One measurements remain the decisive tests and were not run.

7.1 Outcomes by kill test

Own the sweep (rank 6): kill confirmed as a revenue case. Third-party money-market funds pay sweep providers 3 to 50 basis points before 12b-1 fees, typically 15 to 25 [crosscut-91, crosscut-92]. The deposit spread a bank gives up runs from 62 basis points (Wealthfront's program-bank fee) through 74 (Robinhood) to 122 (Schwab's 2025 10-K), with Capital One's Consumer Banking segment near 230 as a ceiling that includes loan income [crosscut-93, crosscut-94, franchise-90]. The fee sits below the spread in every pairing, so a sweep pays to lose the deposit. It survives only as a defensive feature, and only if outbound-flow data show that most swept dollars would have left anyway, which the NBER evidence does not support. Verdict moves from Feature to **Out as a revenue case**.

Joint-account exit and control terms (rank 4): kill confirmed on the complaint test. Checking or savings narratives naming a joint account and an ex-partner or separation ran 8, 12, 21 and 2 a year from 2023 to mid-August 2026, 43 in all, against the adversary's "low hundreds a year" threshold [partnerships-90]. Deposit-side separation pain is not visible at scale. The attrition and conversion legs need Capital One's own data, but the public test is failed. Verdict moves from Feature to **Out**.

T01 depository price edge: kill not met, but T01 stays Out. In HMDA 2024 and 2025 data, depositories price purchase loans lower than independent mortgage companies in every segment: about 0.30 points and $2,000 lower on conventional loans above 90% CLTV, and about 0.12 points and $1,200 lower on FHA loans, after controlling for LTV band, loan amount and term [domicile-90, domicile-91, domicile-92]. The gap is no larger on loans the bank keeps and is as large on low-LTV loans, so its cause looks like borrower mix or fees, not deposit funding. Lender type was inferred from institution names because the Reporter Panel was unpublished, and the public file has no credit score, so the rows are rated Low to Medium [domicile-93]. The claim in Chapter 4 that no price edge exists is retired. T01 stays Out on the other grounds: the bank's two exits, its 2025 statement to the OCC, and the nonbank share [domicile-94]. The 3.6% bank share of FHA and VA lending quoted in the stress test does not reconcile with the 11.9% count share in HMDA and should not be repeated without reconciliation.

T06 heir retention (rank 1): unresolved. No bank, Fed or FDIC source discloses deposits leaving after a death or heir retention. Fifth Third has reported only programme activity (39,000 wills, about 3,000 trusts, 17 months in), with no retention or deposit effect [transfer-90, transfer-91]. CFPB narratives give a frequency: 1,280 death-or-estate complaints in 2024, about 42 per 100,000 deaths, only 31% of them at the deposit account [transfer-92, transfer-93]. Only

Capital One's settlement-check match can settle this.

Family authority over a parent's accounts (rank 2): unresolved, demand objection softened. Huntington's five earnings calls from October 2025 to October 2026 never name Caregiver Banking, and True Link discloses no partner count [caregiving-90, caregiving-91]. One award release claims a third of account holders are new to Huntington and switched for the offering, with no base or method. Power-of-attorney narratives run about 150 a year in checking or savings, mostly agents refused or stalled [caregiving-92]. The two-year window on the kill test closes in August 2027.

T08 agent permissions (rank 8): kill not met for Visa; unresolved for Mastercard and for usage. Visa's Core Rules of 18 April 2026, section 4.1.24.10, make the cardholder responsible for an agent's actions as if the cardholder initiated the transaction, treat the agent provider as the cardholder, add no agent-specific dispute reason code, and require issuers to pay agent transactions without blocking them wholesale [crosscut-95, crosscut-96]. That leaves the liability question with the issuer and its customer, which is the one place an issuer-side permissions feature has a reason to exist. Mastercard's rulebook could not be read. No consumer agent-transaction count exists in any disclosure; Visa and Mastercard report after the research date [crosscut-97, crosscut-98, crosscut-99].

7.2 What changed in the list

- Rank 4 (joint-account exit terms) and rank 6 (deposit sweep option) move to Out. The feature list in Chapter 2 drops from thirteen to eleven.
- Rank 1 and rank 2 stand, still unresolved on demand, still grade C.
- Rank 8 gains a reason to exist (Visa puts agent liability on the cardholder) but no market.
- T01's kill rests on the bank's own exits and the nonbank share, not on price.

7.3 A note on the complaint data

The CFPB stopped publishing complaint narratives on 14 August 2026. The follow-up used an Internet Archive capture of the bulk file from 15 August 2026, streamed and searched locally, with the query code and raw counts saved beside the table. Narratives are opt-in and cover about half of complaints in the four products examined, so every count is a floor. Future passes will not be able to repeat this measurement from the live database.

7.4 The second sweep

Chapter 5.4 recommended a second sweep that starts from positions in money flows and the edges a bank this size can hold. A scout pass sized 18 flows from primary sources and ranked ten position hypotheses, registered as P01 to P10. All ten were researched, compiled and stress-tested, adding 95 rows to the published table under three-digit IDs. Chapter 8 reports the result: one large edge the first sweep could not see (the Regulation II three-party exemption on owned-network debit, worth about 75 to 85 basis points a transaction and already held by the bank), with no consumer product on it; and nine positions that die or narrow to features because the edge is small, already competed away by challengers that became banks, or owned by the platform that holds the customer.

8. The second sweep: positions and edges

Chapter 5 recommended a second sweep that starts from positions in money flows and the edges a bank this size can hold, and asks which life moments they touch, rather than the reverse. A scout pass sized 18 consumer money flows from primary sources (the Fed Payments Study, CMS, IRS, BEA, NAIC, the Bureau of the Fiscal Service), applied the sponsor's Section 5 exclusions, and ranked ten position hypotheses, P01 to P10, each in the sponsor's falsifiable form: a bank holding position X in flow Y could capture Z from W, because of edge E. Each was researched in two slices (supply and right to win), compiled with every number re-verified, and argued down by an adversary. The rows are in the published table under three-digit IDs (independence-101 and up, rupture-101 and up, income-101 and up, domicile-101 and up, worldview-101 and up).

8.1 What the second sweep found

One large edge the first sweep missed, and no consumer product on it. Regulation II's commentary says a three-party system is not a "payment card network", so debit transactions on a network the issuer owns sit outside the interchange cap [independence-102]. Discover debit averaged $0.83 a transaction in the Fed's 2024 table against $0.23 for covered issuers, a gap of about 58 to 60 cents or 75 to 85 basis points at Discover's ticket size [independence-103]. The network fee an issuer avoids by owning the network is only about 1.6 cents a transaction; the prize is the cap, not the fee [independence-101]. Capital One already holds this edge: the Fed's approval order accepted the exemption in a footnote, neither approval order conditions pricing or routing, and the bank's own $1.2B network-synergy target on $175B of migrated volume works out to about 69 basis points [independence-109, independence-110, independence-111]. Its 10-K names the cap being extended to three-party debit as the risk that would remove most of that synergy, and the cap itself is in litigation [independence-112]. Only Capital One and American Express hold such an exemption on debit. No consumer-facing form exists in any disclosure [independence-114], and the obvious one has already been tried: Discover Cashback Debit paid 1% on the first $3,000 of monthly debit spend, stopped taking applications by January 2026, and Discover's checking page now redirects to 360 Checking, which carries no debit reward.

Every other edge is small, already arbitraged, or belongs to someone else.

- *Deposit funding* is worth about 2 points against Affirm on average deposit cost (Affirm's stated funding rate is 4.95%, not the 6% the researchers first computed), about 1 point at the margin, 0.83 against Klarna, which is 88% deposit-funded, and nothing against Synchrony [independence-121 to independence-126]. Block originates through its own industrial bank, PayPal and Affirm have applied for theirs. In personal lending the edge is 16 to 19 basis points against SoFi and 62 to 69 against LendingClub, both now banks, worth about 1.4% of principal over a loan's life against 1.6 to 2.3% of acquisition cost [rupture-101 to rupture-106].
- *The primary-account base* is distribution for products the bank already sells. The receiving account for federal money is a 360 Checking sign-up campaign: the remaining paper-check pool is 40.9M payments a year, paper refunds fell from 8.4M to 2.2M in one season, the April 2026 rule names no preferred provider, and Comerica's whole Direct Express contract earned

$121M of fees against $119M of expense plus $3.4B of free deposits [rupture-121 to rupture-134].

- *Network push* pays the receiving bank, but the wrong one: Visa's October 2026 schedule pays Visa issuers $0.29 to $0.60 per push-to-card credit, Capital One's debit now runs on Discover, and the platform sets and keeps the instant-pay fee ($1.25 to $1.99 per cash-out) while steering earners to its own card by waiving it [income-121 to income-134].
- *Brex and the small-business book* do not reach sole proprietors: Brex serves 25,000 companies, Discover's direct merchant relationships are with large merchants, Capital One's merchant services are a Worldpay referral, business debit is capped like consumer debit, and the sub-$100K tier of sole proprietors holds about $422B of receipts with an $11B card-fee ceiling even if every dollar were paid by card [income-101 to income-114].
- *The international footprint* has no cross-border send product: Discover's push product is US-only, the UK and Canada operations take no deposits and hold about 3% of card loans, and digital remitters price at 0.5% to 2% [worldview-101 to worldview-103].
- *Owned-network pricing on rent* runs the wrong way: the renter pays the card fee (2.95% at RentCafe against free or $0.95 ACH), Colorado capped one processor at 2%, and an uncapped issuer rate makes the card dearer for the merchant, not cheaper [domicile-101 to domicile-103].
- *Patient instalments* meet an incumbent that is itself 84% deposit-funded, with non-exclusive provider contracts terminable on 15 days' notice, so neither funding nor lock-in is the barrier [rupture-141 to rupture-143].

8.2 Verdicts

Position	What stands	Verdict	Grade
P01 Owned-network debit checkout	A real, large edge (the three-party exemption, 75 to 85 bps a transaction) that the bank already holds and that merchants pay. No consumer product; the one tried (Discover Cashback Debit) closed to new applicants in January 2026. Kill limb 1 (the cap extended to three-party debit) is contingent on litigation; limb 2 (acceptance) is open with no independent data.	Margin, not territory	B
P02 Deposit-funded pay-over-time	A funding edge of about 1 to 2 points against Affirm, 0.83 against Klarna, none against Synchrony, worth about 0.3% of GMV; checkout placement belongs to Affirm and Klarna under contract. What a bank can own is an instalment option on its own cards, which Citi Flex Pay already sells.	Feature, not territory	B
P03 Deposit-funded card-debt consolidation	A 16 to 69 bps deposit edge against fintechs that are already banks, below the 1.6 to 2.3% of principal it costs to acquire a borrower; the bank's own policy bars consolidating its own cards; the inherited personal-loan book fell 17% in a year to $7.98B. The adversary found the shrinkage is a deliberate pause (the Q3 2026 call describes a "brownout" on high-balance revolvers with a plan to "lean back in"), so any restart already belongs to the card business.	Out	B
P04 Receiving account for federal money	A small, shrinking pool; a rule that favours no provider; an account the bank already sells and already lists under Bank On. The Direct Express contract is tendered competitively for five years and sits with Fifth Third to about 2030: a procurement date to log, not a position.	Out	B
P05 Sole-proprietor receivables on owned acceptance	Acceptance is won on software and onboarding; business debit is capped; the account is commercial banking the bank already runs.	Out	B
P06 Branded payout destination	The platform keeps the instant-pay fee and steers to its own card; a bare destination is a debit card with early direct deposit, which exists free. Residue: Discover's push pricing could make a Capital One card the best-paid destination (TabaPay began routing pushes to Discover cards in August 2026), but the platform's processor pays the rate and the earner gains only through a rebate of at most about 30% of a $1.99 fee.	Margin, not territory	B
P07 Card rent on owned-network pricing	The renter pays the card fee, and an uncapped issuer rate raises it.	Out	B
P08 Payroll-linked liquidity	Survives narrowly on Chime's MyPay economics alone: about 2.55% of each dollar advanced, mostly instant-delivery fees, which the CFPB's December 2025 opinion shelters only when the provider does not underwrite; at a bank they would be credit charges with a disclosed rate. Free early direct deposit already covers the timing value. Merged into the sweep-1 small-dollar line (Chapter 2, rank 3).	Feature, not territory	C
P09 Cross-border on the owned international network	No send product on the networks; no deposits abroad; the tax exemption helps every provider equally.	Out	B
P10 Patient instalments at the provider	The incumbent is deposit-funded and non-exclusive; the pain is price and coverage.	Out	B

8.3 What this means

Starting from positions and edges found one thing the life-territory sweep could not see: a regulatory exemption worth about $1.2B a year by the bank's own target, with no customer in it. Everything else the sweep tested is a funding or distribution advantage that is small, already competed away by challengers that became banks, or owned by the platform that holds the customer. The pattern is the same as sweep one, seen from the other side: where the bank has an edge, it has no product; where there is a product gap, the bank has no edge.

For the exemption to become a zero-to-one consumer business rather than a pricing decision on the existing debit base, the adversaries set three conditions as the test. The value must reach the person, not stop at the issuer's margin. The payers (merchants on the acquiring side, platforms' processors on the push side) must be unable to route around it, which is why the one place a product could sit is where the bank is both the network setting the rate and the issuer receiving it, as it would be on owned-network push-to-card payouts combined with owned-network debit. And it must win customers who are new to the bank without giving the spread away on accounts it already holds. None of the three is shown today; on the evidence it is a rebate. The measurement is internal and already exists: Discover Cashback Debit's 2019 to 2026 record of accounts opened, the share that became primary within twelve months, and reward paid against spread earned. That record decides whether P01 is a product or a margin before anyone ideates on it.

8.4 Gaps

- Capital One's debit-specific network revenue and the realised synergy, as against the $1.2B target; whether its debit cards carry a second unaffiliated network as Regulation II's routing rule requires; whether "three-party" status holds when the issuing bank and the network are separate subsidiaries. All are internal or need a full-text read of the 2026 filings.
- Discover and PULSE debit acceptance among large merchants, which no independent source measures, and Discover's push-to-card rate, which is unpublished.
- Affirm's and Klarna's ABS coupons, which would settle the marginal funding comparison; Affirm Bank's charter decision.
- Where the share of personal loans used for consolidation sits nationally, and what Capital One's personal-loan plan is.
- Chime's definition of "loss rate" on MyPay, and any employer-integrated EWA loss rate to compare it with.
- The Treasury customer-due-diligence proposal under EO 14406 (due mid-November 2026), which bears on P09 and on sweep one's cross-border residue.

9. The battlefield: acute pain by life stage

The chapters before this one asked whether a bank could win. This one sets that aside. It asks only where financial life goes wrong, how badly, for whom, and in which direction the pain is moving. The right-to-win screens in Chapters 2 to 8 measure the world as it exists: who already sells what, what the rules allow, what a filing discloses. They cannot see what does not yet exist, and a map drawn only from incumbents will always say the field is taken. The pains below are the durable part of the map. Incumbents change; the pains have been measured for years and are mostly getting worse.

Each area gives the pain, the measured size, who carries it, the direction of travel, and what no product does today. "No product" means the sweep found none that resolves the pain for the segment named, not that none could exist. Finding IDs point to the published table; a few items rest on the September 2026 corpus rows that the compile cut for space and are marked as such.

9.1 Shaping One's Financial Worldview

1. **Growing up unbanked.** 4.2% of households are unbanked, but the rate is 10.6% for Black and 9.5% for Hispanic households and about 15% for single parents, and more than half of the children in unbanked households live with a single parent (corpus, FDIC 2023). The next Debit-Primary cohort is forming now, in homes with no account to model. Direction: the national rate falls while the composition concentrates. No product reaches the child through the parent who has no account.
2. **Money views that form outside any institution.** The channels that shape a worldview are school, family and social media, none of them a transaction [worldview-15, worldview-23]. School financial education was bank-funded for CRA credit and written off [worldview-10]. Early independent accounts for minors raise ownership at 16 to 19 and leave no banked advantage by 24, followed by worse credit at 21 to 24 [worldview-20]. Direction: the influence mix is moving to social channels that sell investing, not banking. The pain is that the first financial decisions are made on advice no one is accountable for.
3. **The immigrant money life that fades by the third generation.** First-generation households send money home (15% of second-generation Asian American adults, 4% in the third) and distrust banks at twice the rate of others (36.3% of unbanked households cite distrust) [worldview-18, worldview-19]. The sending base is shrinking (a net loss of 533,208 Mexican remitters in 2025) while the cost of sending through a bank is the highest of any channel [worldview-16, worldview-03]. Direction: enforcement and due-diligence rules in 2026 push this population further from banks [worldview-13]. No bank product treats the household's two-country financial life as one.
4. **Saving behaviour that follows the paycheck, not the upbringing.** The same low-income households look present-biased before payday and not after, and relabelling savings does not raise them [worldview-21]. Direction: stable, and it says the lever is timing, not education. The pain is that every product aimed at "financial literacy" is aimed at the wrong variable.

9.2 Becoming Financially Independent

1. **The $0 retirement start.** 50.4% of households headed by someone under 35 hold no retirement account, so the median young household has $0 in retirement savings, while 98.6% hold a transaction account [independence-16]. Non-investors' top reason is too little money (44.9%), not distrust (5.0%) [independence-17]. Retirement wealth ($49.1T) flows through employers and recordkeepers, around the bank [independence-18]. Direction: auto-enrolment and the 2027 Saver's Match will move it, through employers and tax returns. The gap is between the account the young hold and the one the match reaches.
2. **First credit through buy-now-pay-later.** 37.1% of 18-to-24-year-olds with a credit record used BNPL in 2022, and 61% of BNPL originations went to subprime or deep-subprime scores [independence-21]. Credit invisibility has fallen to 2.7% of adults, but about two-thirds of 18-to-19-year-olds are invisible, so the on-ramp has moved to pay-in-4 loans that mostly do not report [independence-19]. Direction: BNPL volume is rising and bureau reporting is only now starting. The pain is a first credit history built where no one can see it.
3. **Student debt that is a policy event, not a loan.** 16% of adults hold student loans, 23% of borrowers report recent payment difficulty on affordability, and student loans carry the highest serious-delinquency flow of any major debt (7.83%) [independence-81]. More than 5 million defaulted borrowers face Treasury offset, and almost 10 million could be in default within months [rupture-21]. Direction: the July 2026 caps push graduate borrowers to private credit at prime terms only. The pain concentrates in people with incomplete degrees, who are not the refinancing market.
4. **The dated cliffs of separation.** Young adults cross fixed dates with financial consequences: credit at 21, bank fee cut-offs at 25 at many institutions, loss of parental health cover at 26, when dependent coverage falls from 93% at 18 to 19 to 50% at 24 to 25 [independence-23]. Parents fund the gap: 59% gave financial help in the past year, and transfers are three to five times likelier in advantaged families [independence-22]. Direction: later, longer, more unequal. No product treats the separation as a process with dates.
5. **Access converged, outcomes diverged.** Stock ownership rose to 58% of families and fund fees fell to 0.32%, yet the bottom half's conditional median stock holding is $12,600 against $608,000 for the top decile, and the bottom 50% is losing share of real estate and pension wealth while gaining share only in deposits (corpus, wave 3). Direction: widening in dollars while narrowing in percent. The deposit account is the only asset the bottom half is gaining.

9.3 Forming and Dissolving Partnerships

1. **Couples who keep money apart.** Married couples with no joint account rose from 15% to 23% between 1996 and 2023, and only 16% of cohabiting couples hold one [partnerships-17]. 54% of a survey sample say they share finances while 44.9% are identifiable as linked in credit data [partnerships-18]. Direction: toward separate accounts and ledger apps. The pain is coordination without pooling, for which the banking system offers only the joint account that either owner can empty [partnerships-02].

2. **Unmarried unions that end without a decree.** Cohabitors grew from 15.2M to 18.4M, peaking at ages 25 to 29 [partnerships-16]. Dissolution of cohabiting unions formed at 18 to 25 rose from 27.6% to 45.2% across birth cohorts while marital dissolution fell [partnerships-21]. Direction: the main way young couples split is now the one with no legal process for dividing anything. The pain is a breakup with joint obligations and no referee.
3. **The mortgage that will not let go.** After divorce or death, homeowners wait months to years for a release, successor status or assumption, against federal timeframes of about 45 days, and servicers press successors to refinance at higher rates [partnerships-20, transfer-20]. Direction: rates above the locked-in level make the wait costlier. No product moves a home between the people who live in it without the servicer's consent.
4. **Grey divorce.** The overall divorce rate fell from 4.0 to 2.4 per 1,000, but divorce among women 55 to 64 rose from 4 to 11 per 1,000 married women [partnerships-19]. These separations divide retirement accounts (the September corpus holds GAO data on qualified domestic relations orders and a $757 average forgone employer match among separating workers). Direction: rising at the one age where there is no time to rebuild. The pain is dividing the assets that were supposed to last.
5. **Coerced debt.** Debt taken in a partner's name under duress is documented in the corpus at prevalence levels the compile cut for space, and the CFPB's coerced-debt rulemaking stalled at an advance notice in 2024 [partnerships-11]. Direction: no rule coming. The pain is credit damage with no remedy short of litigation.

9.4 Establishing Domicile

1. **Rent that takes a third of income, and falls behind.** 49.7% of the 42.5M renter households spend more than 30% of income on housing, 56.2% among Black renters [domicile-19]. 23% of renters were behind on rent in the past year, up 6 points since 2021, and 33% of renters earning under $25,000 [domicile-20, domicile-81]. Direction: worsening every year measured. The pain is the largest monthly payment arriving before the money does, and rent timing is now a business at 3.2M renters [domicile-10].
2. **The down payment, not the mortgage.** 68% of renters cite the down payment as the reason they do not own, against 42% citing qualification; nearly 90% lack the 3.5% FHA minimum for an average home; the median first-time buyer is now 40 [domicile-22]. 26% of all buyers pay cash and over half of repeat buyers fund the down payment from a prior sale [domicile-23]. Direction: the ladder's first rung is rising faster than incomes. No product accumulates a down payment for a Debit-Primary renter on any timeline that matches a life.
3. **Rent history that counts for nothing.** Only 8% of renters have rent reported to a bureau, positive rent history is on file for 1.7% to 2.3%, and screening errors persist (16,000 complaints) [domicile-21, domicile-26, domicile-25]. Direction: the GSEs now read rent from bank data and FHFA approved new scores in April 2026, so the rule moved before the product did. The pain is a decade of on-time payments that build no record.
4. **Entry costs and screening at the door.** 68% of renters pay application fees; deposits, move-in costs and screening fees are unmeasured in any authoritative source; New York caps deposits at one month and Cincinnati mandates alternatives, and the FTC opened a rental-fee

rulemaking in March 2026 [domicile-25, domicile-14, domicile-15]. Direction: regulators are moving against the gate. The pain is a cash wall at the moment of moving.

5. **Insurance that is withdrawing.** Homeowners premiums rose 8.7% faster than inflation and the riskiest ZIP codes pay 82% more; 6% of homeowners carry no insurance, 43% of them because they cannot afford it; 14% of adults were financially affected by a disaster in 2025 [domicile-24, domicile-82]. California's FAIR Plan grew 157% since 2022 [domicile-17]. Direction: state by state, with the exposure moving to public pools. The pain is an uninsurable home that is also the household's largest asset.

9.5 Income Maturity

1. **Hours that move.** 30% of adults say their income varies and 11% struggle to pay bills because of it; among adults earning under $25,000 it is 19% [income-01, income-20]. The swings come from employers changing hours, not workers changing jobs [income-19]. Direction: stable at a high level for four years. The pain is a paycheck whose size is set weekly by someone else, and the only products that address it sell speed on earned pay at about $69 a year [income-02].
2. **The refund as the year's biggest cash event.** 104M taxpayers (63% of filers) received a refund averaging $3,167, and refund day is the peak cash-flow day of the year for 29% of refund-receiving families [income-23]. Lump sums cut rent arrears where monthly payments did not [income-25]. 97% of eligible filers do not use free filing [income-24]. Direction: 2026 refunds jumped 11% on unadjusted withholding, and the paper check is gone [income-16]. The pain is a year's over-withholding returned once, through a preparer's product, to people who needed it monthly.
3. **Platform earnings with no home.** 20% of adults did gig work in the prior month and 21% of them call it their main job [income-22]; DoorDash alone paid $20B to 9M people in 2025 [income-129]; an earner cashing out early pays $1.25 to $1.99 per transfer unless they take the platform's own card [income-121]. Direction: multi-platform earning is the norm (about 4 in 10 in 2021) and no account is built for it [income-130]. The pain is income arriving in pieces from several payers, each steering the earner to a different account.
4. **The sole proprietor whose business money is personal money.** 25.6M of 28.4M sole-proprietor returns report under $100K of receipts, holding $422B [income-101]. Regulation E covers only personal accounts, the incumbents route sole proprietors into business accounts, and Capital One's own offer to them is business checking at $15 to $99 a month with card acceptance referred to Worldpay [income-111, income-113]. Direction: 31.99M nonemployer firms and growing. The pain is a person who is a business in the eyes of every payment provider and a consumer in the eyes of their own bank.
5. **The bypassed paycheck.** For the bottom half, the deposit account is close to the only relationship that generates financial data (34% hold any stock against 98.6% holding an account) [income-21], yet retirement wealth is intermediated at payroll and at rollover, around that account [independence-18, transfer-21]. Direction: the Saver's Match will route through tax returns and employer plans. The pain is that the one account these households have is the one every wealth flow avoids.

9.6 Caregiving Obligation

1. **Child care at a quarter of income.** Families below the poverty line pay a median 23 to 27% of income for child care, against 7 to 8% at three times poverty [caregiving-15]; among families paying for both, median child care ($1,083 a month) is more than half the housing payment [caregiving-80]. 46% of children under 6 live in a licensed-care desert, 70% in remote rural areas [caregiving-16]. Direction: the pandemic funding cliff passed in 2024 and the 2026 tax changes help only those with tax liability [caregiving-17, caregiving-14]. The pain is price and supply, and it falls on the parent's earning capacity.
2. **The sandwich.** 7.6M of 38.2M unpaid eldercare providers also have a child under 18 at home; 54% of people in their 40s are sandwiched [caregiving-19]. Spousal caregivers aged 59 to 66 hold 50% less in IRA assets than married non-caregivers [caregiving-20]. Direction: later childbearing and longer lifespans lengthen the overlap. The pain is two dependencies at once, paid in time and lost earnings, which no financial product measures.
3. **Running a parent's money.** Adult children pay a parent's bills through shared logins, card and PIN sharing, or a joint account that exposes the parent to the child's creditors [caregiving-13]. The CFPB has asked banks for view-only access since 2016; power-of-attorney narratives run about 150 a year in checking complaints, mostly agents refused or stalled [caregiving-08, caregiving-92]. Direction: the first large bank shipped delegated access in 2025. The pain is authority over a parent's account without a safe way to hold it.
4. **Long-term care paid out of pocket.** Adults turning 65 in 2021 to 2025 face lifetime out-of-pocket long-term care of $75,400 in the top income quintile and $15,400 in the bottom [caregiving-21], and family caregivers are paid, if at all, through Medicaid programmes with their own payroll intermediaries [caregiving-07]. Direction: rising with longevity. The pain is a six-figure liability that arrives late, unplanned and uninsured.
5. **Elder exploitation by the people closest.** A family member figures in 46% of elder-theft cases in FinCEN's 2013 to 2019 sample, and adult children in nearly 40% of theft cases in its 2024 analysis, though strangers' scams are the larger share of filings [caregiving-12]. Direction: scams rising faster than theft. The pain is that the delegate a parent needs is also the most likely thief.

9.7 Transfer Between Generations

1. **The inheritance that arrives at 60.** Receipt peaks at 11.2% over five years for households aged 56 to 65 against 5.0% under 26, and at least half of recipients get their first transfer after 40 [transfer-16]. The pool is concentrated in wealthy households, and the $84T to $124T headline is a vendor projection [transfer-15]. Direction: later and more unequal as lifespans lengthen. The pain for the Debit-Primary heir is receiving a modest sum, once, at an age when it changes little.
2. **The executor's job.** Probate filings rose 3% from 2018 to 2022 while civil filings fell 17%, so probate is now 10% of the civil caseload [transfer-17]. Most estates settle without litigation, but compensation runs about 2.9% of estate value even when undisputed [transfer-18]. Small-estate affidavits reach $50,000 to $208,850 depending on the state [transfer-10].

Direction: more deaths, more filings. The pain is an unpaid administrative job with legal exposure, done once by someone who has never done it.

3. **The survivor who inherits a bill.** New surviving spouses with unpaid medical bills carry $28,749 on average against $15,785 for others, and collectors pursue non-liable survivors [transfer-19]. Servicers press heirs to refinance at higher rates and take months to years to recognise them [transfer-20]. The reverse-mortgage heir clock runs 30 days (corpus). Direction: 1,280 death-or-estate complaints in 2024, 69% of them in mortgage servicing and debt collection, not at the deposit account [transfer-92, transfer-93]. The pain is a death that triggers four deadlines held by four counterparties.
4. **Retirement money that stays with the recordkeeper.** At separation 58% of plan assets stay in the plan and 36% roll to an IRA; installments take under 0.5% [transfer-05]. Defined-benefit participants fell from 42M to 29M while defined-contribution participation grew [transfer-21]. Direction: the pension is gone, and what replaced it has no income feature anyone uses. The pain is a lump sum with no instruction manual, at the one moment a mistake cannot be undone.
5. **Co-signed and inherited debt.** Private student loans co-signed by parents, HELOCs and reverse mortgages passed to heirs, and auto-default on a co-signer's death are documented in the September corpus and in the CFPB's successor-in-interest work [transfer-22]. Direction: a HECM back book of 681,000 loans ages into estates. The pain is debt the heir did not take out and cannot see coming.

9.8 Rupture and Recovery

1. **The $400 that one in eight cannot find.** 63% of adults would cover a $400 expense with cash or its equivalent; 12% could not pay it by any means; 37% would not cover it with cash, a share unchanged for four years [rupture-16, rupture-80]. 37% of the lowest-income households could cover $1,600 against 97% of the highest [rupture-17]. Direction: flat at a high level. The pain is a buffer that does not exist for a quarter of households, filled today by overdraft, cards, pay-in-4 and advance apps at an illustrative 109.5% APR [rupture-18].
2. **Medical debt in every income band.** About 23M adults owe medical debt, 3M more than $10,000 [rupture-19]; 57% of adults under $40,000 hold health-care debt, and 26% skipped care because of cost in 2025 [rupture-20, rupture-82]. Direction: the credit-reporting rule was vacated in 2025 and coverage losses are projected under the 2025 budget act. The pain is an unplanned bill from a provider who sets the price after the service.
3. **Default and the long shadow.** More than 5M student-loan borrowers in default face offset [rupture-21]; bankruptcy filers recover their scores within a year but face credit limits of 10 to 15% of the prior peak for at least six quarters [rupture-23]. Direction: offsets restarted in May 2025. The pain is recovery that is complete in the score and incomplete in access.
4. **Debt that is a subscription, not an event.** 45% of card owners revolve, card balances are $1.263T, and 6.97% flow to serious delinquency [rupture-81]; fintech consolidation borrowers re-lever within months and balance transfers moved $59.5B in 2024 at a 4.3% fee [rupture-110]. Direction: rising with rates. The pain is revolving debt that no product ends, only moves.

5. **The shock that hits the retirement account.** Adults with a major unexpected expense borrowed from, cashed out or cut contributions to a retirement account at about twice the rate of others [rupture-22], and vehicle repair is the most common major shock, hitting 30% of adults [rupture-83]. Direction: every shock drains the one asset the bottom half is gaining. The pain is a liquidity problem solved with a retirement problem.

9.9 Cross-cutting

1. **Idle money that is not idle.** Balances above $25,000 show no response to rate spreads inside a bank, yet $1.2T moved into money-market funds in 2023 and deposit betas rose to 0.5 in a year [crosscut-16, crosscut-17, crosscut-18]. The pain, for the household, is yield forgone through inattention or liquidity need; for the bank, it is the same dollars leaving when attention arrives.
2. **Fees the system still takes.** Banks collected $12.1B in overdraft and NSF fees in 2024 and $12.4B in 2025 after the cap was repealed, paid mostly by adults under $25,000 (16% against 6% above $100,000) [crosscut-21, crosscut-22]. Direction: the rule is gone; the fees returned. The pain is a penalty priced on the people with the least buffer.
3. **Money that will move without a person.** Agent-initiated payments exist in rules and protocols with no measured consumer volume, and Visa's 2026 rules make the cardholder liable for the agent's actions [crosscut-12, crosscut-95]. Direction: the liability landed before the market did. The pain is not here yet, and when it arrives it will land on the customer first.

9.10 Where the battlefield is densest

Four pains recur across stages and segments and are getting worse on the record: **the missing buffer** (rupture, income, caregiving), **the largest payment arriving before the money** (domicile, income), **authority over someone else's money** (partnerships, caregiving, transfer), and **wealth flows that bypass the only account the bottom half has** (independence, income, transfer). The sponsor's seeds touched each of these, and the right-to-win screens narrowed each to a feature because an incumbent already sells a piece of it. That is a statement about today's supply, not about the pain. The pains are the ground; the ideation should start here and treat the incumbents in Chapters 2 to 8 as the current occupants, not the terrain.